

Sood-led panel to review DU hostel shortage gap

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University is set to more than double its hostel capacity, with the total seats across the university and its colleges expected to reach 12,754, while Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has formed a 18-member high-powered committee headed by Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood to assess demand-supply gap in residential facilities for the students and ensure land availability for their accommodation.

These far-reaching decisions come in the wake of the Satya Niketan building collapse, killing seven, including five students staying there. While plans to expand hostel accommodation for Delhi University students have been in the works for the past few years, the recent building collapse at

Satya Niketan and the subsequent protests by students demanding accountability have brought renewed focus on expediting this process. "Construction of hostels for these new seats is currently underway and is expected to be completed in the coming months," according to university administration officials.

According to the university, the hostel capacity across Delhi University colleges will rise from 3,788 seats by an additional 1,622 seats, bringing the total to 5,410. As a result, the combined hostel capacity of the university and its colleges will increase to 12,754 seats. The university's latest push to augment hostel capacity comes amid growing concerns over the availability of safe and affordable accommodation for students, particularly those coming from outside Delhi.

Several hostel projects are currently under construction and are expected to be completed in the coming months. An Institute of Eminence (IoE) hostel with a capacity of 1,450 seats is nearing completion at the university's Dhaka Complex. A 1,000-seat women's hostel, named 'Nirbhaya Residential Accommodation', is also being constructed, a statement by the university added.

A studio apartment complex with a capacity of 1,050 seats is among the other projects under construction, while work on several additional hostel projects is expected to begin soon.

Moreover, the University of Delhi plans to submit several new hostel project proposals to the government in the near future. The university has asked principals of all its colleges to review the resi-



dential facilities available to students and expedite the completion of any hostel projects already under construction. The principals have also been asked to explore the feasibility of constructing new hostels on their campus-

es and prepare plans wherever adequate space and other requirements are available. The university has advised colleges to assess available land, government schemes and other requirements before initiating construc-

tion of new hostel facilities. In a related development, Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu has formed a 18 member inter-agency committee comprises Chief Secretary, Commissioner of Police, Commissioner MCD,

Chairman NDMC, Vice Chairman DDA and vice chancellors of DU, GGSIPU, Ambedkar University and NSUT, apart from other senior officials. Secretary (Education) will be member secretary of the committee. Sandhu had issued direction for the formation of the committee in a meeting also attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday, in the backdrop of Satya Niketan tragedy in which seven people, including five students, lost their lives in the collapse of a five-storey paying guest (PG) accommodation last Sunday. The panel will also prescribe emergency evacuation and disaster-response protocols for student accommodation and suggest a centralised digital monitoring mechanism for students to report unsafe housing. It will submit its recommendations within 60

days, a Lok Niwas note said. The Committee will provide overarching policy direction, ensure inter-departmental coordination and monitor implementation of measures relating to student accommodation and safety across the Capital, it said. It will also suggest establishing a mechanism through which students can report unsafe accommodation, overcrowding, fire hazards or other serious safety concerns, with time-bound action. To this effect suggest development of a centralised digital monitoring/dashboard.

The committee mandate will be to assess the existing gap between student demand and available hostel accommodation in Delhi, exploring creation and expansion of student accommodation through universities, MCD, DDA and other government agencies, the Lok Niwas said.

DDA steps up MPD 2047 consultation process

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) held its second and third stakeholder consultations on the Master Plan for Delhi 2047 on Thursday. The consultations brought together key Government departments, service agencies and heritage conservation bodies to discuss how the Plan's provisions can be effectively implemented on the ground.

The meetings were held in line with directions from Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, who has emphasised ensuring that MPD 2047 translates into tangible benefits for Delhi's residents rather than combining

a policy document. The first consultation in the series was held earlier with public representatives, including Members of Parliament and MLAs from Delhi.

The second meeting brought together representatives from major service-providing agencies, including the New Delhi Municipal Council, Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Jal Board, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, Delhi Transport Corporation, National Highways Authority of India, National Capital Region Transport Corporation, Delhi Police and the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board. Representatives from several Delhi Government departments also participated, including Public Works, Power,

Land and Building, Fire, Irrigation and Flood Control, and Forest departments. Additional participants at the second meeting included Indraprastha Gas Limited, the National Buildings Construction Corporation, the Central Public Works Department and the Institute of Town Planners, India.

The third stakeholder meeting, held the same day, focused specifically on heritage conservation, bringing together conservation architects, Delhi Tourism, the Archaeological Survey of India, School of Planning and Architecture, INTACH, the Department of Archaeology, Indraprastha Virasat Punarvikas Nigam, MCD, the Delhi Urban Art Commission,

Delhi Fire Service, and the Union Ministry of Culture.

At both meetings, DDA officials provided an overview of the Master Plan's major provisions before opening the floor to detailed discussions on implementation and inter-departmental coordination.

According to DDA, the thematic consultations planned over the coming months will cover a broad set of issues under MPD 2047, including land pooling, redevelopment of group housing societies, management of low-density areas, protection of the Yamuna and blue-green zones, heritage conservation, development of mixed-use and commercial areas, in-situ slum redevelopment, decongestion measures.

Delhi speeds up formation of SDRF

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has accelerated the process to raise a State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) for efficient and quick response to natural and man-made calamities in the wake of recent Satya Niketan building collapse that claimed seven lives.

In a meeting of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta with senior National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) officials at the Delhi Secretariat, necessary inputs were gathered for the state-of-the-art SDRF team, the CMO Delhi said on Thursday.

The NDRF officials briefed the chief minister on various aspects of setting up the disaster response force in Delhi. They said a battalion of the SDRF could be raised in Delhi, comprising upto 1,100 personnel, it said in a statement.

The battalion would func-



tion under the state government and in the event of a disaster, would be able to reach the site quickly and carry out effective relief and rescue operations, the chief minister said.

The NDRF would provide the necessary training to personnel of the proposed SDRF. It would also assist with specialised equipment, keeping in mind Delhi's geographical conditions and local requirements, the CMO said.

The chief minister directed officials to share a list of disaster management equipment and details of its storage with the departments concerned so that

the equipment can be made available immediately in the event of an accident or disaster.

After raising the SDRF, the Delhi Government will also provide specialised training to its fire department staff and Civil Defence volunteers so that local manpower has the necessary skills and can contribute to relief and rescue operations with better coordination during disasters, the chief minister said.

As Delhi is India's capital and several important institutions are located in the city, presence of NDRF personnel in Central, North and South Delhi is also necessary, officials of the force said.



The Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited
Ansal Plaza New Delhi GSTIN: 07AAACT6167G1Z9J
CIN: L65110JK19385GGC000048

B-205 SECOND FLOOR ANSAL PLAZA KHELGAN MARG ANDREWS GUNJ NEW DELHI T: +91-(0)11-26258850, 26264331 F: +91-(0)11-26264331 Email: ansal@jkbmail.com W: www.jkb.bank.in

Ref. No. JKBI/ANSAL/ADV/26-27/468

Dated: 10-09-2026

Registered A.D.
Borrower/Mortgagor: Mr. Rajiv Jain S/O Mr. Subash Jain
R/O Second Floor, Pvt.No. 302 and 303, Village Nasipur, Colony Known as Indra Park, Palam Colony, New Delhi-110045. **Mobile: 7982657372**

DEMAND NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT-2002.
Dear Sir,
This Demand Notice Under Section 13 (2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (hereinafter referred to as "The Act") is issued by me, **Sanjeev Gupta, on 24th day of August, 2026, as Authorized Officer of Jammu and Kashmir Bank Ltd** duly empowered in accordance with the provisions of SARFAESI Act, 2002 for the reasons stated hereinafter:
Whereas, Business unit, Ansal Plaza, New Delhi of Jammu and Kashmir Bank, (hereinafter called Bank) sanctioned various credit facilities details whereof:
a) **Housing Loan of Rs. 50, 60,000/-wide sanctioned Ref. No. JKBI/ANSAL/ADV/2023/_ dated 18-01-2024, to you (herein after also referred as borrower).**
Whereas above said credit facility was secured by following securities:
Primary security: Equitable Mortgage of Property Being built up Second Floor, Back Side, PVT No. 302 and 303, without roof rights, built up property bearing no.D-4 area measuring (50+50) 100 sq. yards, out of total area measuring 200 sq. yards, out of khasra no. 650, situated in revenue estate of Village Nasipur colony known as Indra Park, Palam Colony, New Delhi-110045, with proportionate rights of the land underneath.
Collateral Security: Nil.
Whereas the above said credit facilities were availed by you as borrower after creation of security interest in the above referred properties (secured Assets) in favour of the Bank, Whereas, borrower has failed to maintain the credit facility as per terms and conditions of the above referred sanction letter/s and other terms and conditions laid down in the documents executed by borrower in favour of the Bank, consequently borrower loan account No 0408265500001755 has been classified by the Bank as Non-Performing Asset on 28-01-2026 in accordance with the directives and guidelines of the Reserve Bank of India. The details of loan account are as under:

S. No.	Facility	Sanctioned Limit	Limit Availed	Date of NPA	Amount of NPA	Un-applied Interest	Total outstanding as on 20-08-2026
1.	Housing Loan	Rs. 50,60,000/-	Rs. 50,59,023/-	28-01-2026	49,60,311.13	Rs. 3,50,892.28	53,11,203.41
	Grand Total	Rs. 50,60,000/-	Rs. 50,59,023/-	28-01-2026	49,60,311.13	Rs. 3,50,892.28	53,11,203.41

In addition to amount outstanding as on 20-08-2026, Bank, as secured creditor, reserves the right to claim amount which may become due on account of crystallization of BG's and/or devolvement of LC's (if any)
Total outstanding as on 20-08-2026 is **Rs.53,11,203.41**
Whereas the above said amount is due and payable from you as borrower in the books of accounts of the Bank.
Now since borrower has failed and neglected to make payment of dues in respect of the said Loan duly secured by the securities mentioned hereinabove, and classification of borrowers account as a Non-Performing Asset, I above named as Authorized Officer in exercise of the powers vested in me under the provisions of SARFAESI Act, 2002 and rules made there under hereby give borrower notice under sub-section (2) of section 13 of Securities and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, and call upon borrower to pay in full and discharge borrower liabilities aggregating to **Rs. 53,11,203.41 (Rupees Fifty Three Lak Eleven Thousand Two Hundred and Three and Forty One Paise Only)** as stated herein above, together with interest at contractual rate thereon w. e. f. **31-07-2026** along with other charges and costs to be incurred by the Bank from time to time and thereby discharge in full all borrowers liabilities to the Bank within a period of 60 days from the date of this Notice failing which the Bank shall at borrowers costs and risk exercise its powers under the Act.
We further give borrower notice that in case of failure to pay the above mentioned outstanding amount with interest and costs till the date of payment within the stipulated period of 60 days, we shall be free to exercise all or any of the rights under sub-section (4) of section 13 of the said Act and;
i) In the event of borrower's failure to pay amount as demanded, Bank is authorized under the Act to take possession, control and or management of the above mentioned secured asset together with the right to transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale, without the intervention of the court.
ii) All expenses incurred in the process shall be debited to borrower account and will be recovered from borrower. Moreover in the event of sale of the secured asset borrower liability is not discharged in full, Bank shall have right to recover the remaining balance from borrower.
iii) This demand notice is without prejudice to and shall not be construed as waiver of any other rights or remedies which Bank may have including the right to make further demands in respect of sums owing to Bank.
iv) Section 13 (13) of the Act restrains borrower/mortgagor after the date of this notice from transferring by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of secured assets provided in to this notice, without prior written consent of the Bank and breach of the said provision is an offence punishable under Section 29 of the Act.
v) This demand notice is recall of the loan amount and demand by the secured creditor of the outstanding amount without prejudice to the rights of the Bank to proceed as against the borrower / company / Directors / mortgagors / guarantors for initiating recovery proceedings under any other legal remedies.
vi) Borrower is also informed that it can redeem the secured asset within the time frame prescribed by section 13(8) of the Act.

Sanjeev Gupta
Sd/- Authorized Officer.

PUBLIC NOTICE

BEFORE THE REGIONAL DIRECTOR (NORTHERN REGION)
MINISTRY OF CORPORATE AFFAIRS, NEW DELHI
IN THE MATTER OF SECTION 12(5) OF COMPANIES ACT, 2013
AND
IN THE MATTER OF M/S. PRABHU NIWAS PVT. LTD.
.....PETITIONER

Notice is hereby given to the general public that the company proposes to make an application to the Regional Director (Northern Region) under Section 12(5) and 13 of Companies Act, 2013 and rule 28 of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014, seeking confirmation for shifting the Registered Office of the Company from the jurisdiction of the **Registrar of Companies (ROC)-I** to the jurisdiction of the **Registrar of Companies (ROC)-II**, within the State of New Delhi, involving an alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company.

Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change of the registered office may intimate their nature of interest and grounds of opposition to the Regional Director (Northern Region) within 21 (twenty-one) days from the date of publication of this notice, with a mandatory copy sent to the applicant company at its registered office address mentioned below.

Registered Office:- 4735/11, 22, Prakash Deep Building Ansari Road, Dayarganj, New Delhi-110022.

Proposed Registered Office:- E4/15, Ashoka Centre Block E4, Jhandewalan Extension, Paharganj, New Delhi-110055

For Prabhu Niwas Private Limited

Kartik Das
(Director)
DIN: 10785062

Date:- 11/09/2026

Place:- New Delhi

The Pioneer Classified

• CHANGE OF NAME •

I, **L Chandra Sakhi Singha**

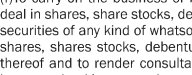
W/o JC-548869H Ex-Sub Late M Jugindra Singha, R/o- Vill- Singerbond Pt-IV, P.O- Dolugram, PS- Lakhpur, Dist- Cachar, State- Assam, Pin- 788101 have changed my name and date of birth from L Chandra Sakhi Singha DOB- 05 Mar 1964 to L Chandrasakhi Singha DOB- 15 Dec 1966 vide affidavit dated 09/09/2026 before 1st Class Magistrate, Silchar, Cachar, Assam.

I, **Ruksana W/o JC-474289W** Nb Sub Clk Mohammad Ashiq, R/o- Vill- Wazirganj, PO- Wazirganj, Teh- Bisauli, Distt- Badaun, U.P - 202526, have changed my name from Ruksana to Ruksana Ansari, vide affidavit dated 10/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Mohammad Latif Khan, S/o Abdul Wahid Khan**, R/o R-109, Gali No.7, Jogabai Extension, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have changed my 17-year-old minor son's name from Owais Khan to Mohammad Owais Khan for all future purposes.

I, **Vikash Singh (UID: 3349 4606 4375) S/o Birendra Singh R/o A-1/2, Plot No-2 S/F, Vrindavan Apartment, Gali No. 1, Near Gaur Public School, Raja Puri, Uttam Nagar, Delhi-110059.** Hereby declare that I have changed my name from Vikash Kandari to Vikash Singh one and the same person.

I, **Kavita Kandari (UID: 236961432190) W/o Vikash Singh R/o A-1/2, Plot No-2 S/F, Vrindavan Apartment, Gali No. 1, Near Gaur Public School, Raja Puri, Uttam Nagar, Delhi-110059.** Hereby declare that I have changed my name from Kavita to Kavita Kandari for all purposes. Henceforth Kavita and Kavita Kandari one and the same person.



SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.
Corporate Off. : 503 & 504, 9th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051.
Regd. Off. : Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

POSSESSION NOTICE FOR IMMOVABLE PROPERTY [Appendix IV] Rule 8(1)
WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. a Housing Finance Company (duly registered with National Housing Bank (fully owned by RBI)) (hereinafter referred to as "SMHFC") under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(2) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice dated mentioned below under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon **within 60 days** from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has **Taken Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned herein in above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of "SMHFC" for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Demand Notice Date & Amount	Date of Possession
1.	1. Sandeep Kumar, S/o. Prem Chand, S/o. Kashmiri Lal, 3. Ritika, W/o. Sandeep Kumar	All The Piece And Parcel Of The Property Area Measuring 62.2 Sq.Yards, Situated At Abadi Deh Of Main Bazar, Village Blasipur, H.No. 279, Tehsil- Blasipur, District- Yamunagar, Recorded In The Name Of Sandeep Kumar S/O Prem Chand, Vide Regd. Transfer Deed 2691 Dated 17-12-2014, Bounded As East- Property Of Prem Chand, West- Road Main Bazar, North- Shop Of Mohan Lal, South- Shop Of Lala Puran Chand.	19.06.2026 Rs. 24,89,134.48/- (Rs. Twenty Four Lakh Eighty Nine Thousand One Hundred Thirty Four & Paise Forty Eight Only) as on 11.06.2026	09.09.2026
2.	1. Sanjay Prabhati, S/o. Prabhathi Singh, 2. Dholi Devi, W/o. Sanjay Singh	All The Piece And Parcel Of The Property Area Measuring 3 Marla, Comprised In Khatw No. 460/419, Khatoni No. 580 And Khasra No. 191/9/6/300(0-3), As Per Jamabandi Year 2021-22, Situated At Village Farsi, Tehsil & District- Hissar, Recorded In The Name Of Smt. Dholi Devi W/O Sh. Sanjay Singh, Vide Regd. Sale Deed No. 3908 Dated 03-07-2024.	19.06.2026 Rs. 9,80,970.73/- (Rs. Nine Lakh Eighty Thousand Nine Hundred Seventy & Paise Seventy Three Only) as on 11.06.2026	08.09.2026

Place : Yamunagar, Hissar, Haryana
Date : 09.09.2026 / 08.09.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

PUBLIC NOTICE

M/S Signatureglobal (India) Limited has been granted Environmental Clearance by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Government of India for Proposed Residential Colony Project Under NLP Policy at Village- Fazlipur Jharsa, Sector-71, District-Gurugram, Haryana vide EC identification no. EC2683812HR5830799N and File No. SEACHR/HR/2026/178 dated 21/08/2026. The copy of Environmental clearance along with the conditions to be complied with is available at office of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change IA Division, and on the website at <http://parivesh.nic.in> and also available at the registered office of the company at 13th Floor, Dr. Gopal Das Bhawan, 28 Barakhamba Road, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001 and also on website of the company at www.signatureglobal.in.

Sd/-
Authorized Signatory
For Signatureglobal (India) Limited
CIN: L70100DL2000PLC104787
Address: 13th Floor, Dr. Gopal Das Bhawan, 28 Barakhamba Road, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

IN FOCUS



United States Ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, with Rajiya Sabha MP Harsh V Shringla takes a ride on the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway during his visit in Darjeeling

Rahul vows justice for slain Manipuri musician

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday vowed to get justice for the slain Manipuri musician Chongtham Vikram Singh and said it has become a fashion in the country for the powerful to be violent and arrogant.

The leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha said incidents like the “murder” of Vikram Singh have been happening too much in the country and asserted that “we stand against it, will fight and defeat it”.

“It is a tragedy on many accounts. It is a tragedy that a young man has been murdered. It is also a tragedy that he was attacked because of where he was from, it is a tragedy for people of Manipur. Of course, it is not the only tragedy that people of Manipur have been facing, you have been facing huge tragedies again and again and again over the last few years. “It is a tragedy



Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi during a memorial service for late Manipuri musician Chongtham Vikram Singh in New Delhi, Thursday

because an amazing talent has been taken away, it is a tragedy because his son will never see his father and his parents will never see their son again,” the former Congress chief said.

It doesn't matter whether it is a mistake or not as there was violence, hatred and arrogance in the act, he said. “It is something that has become a fashion these

days that if you are powerful, you can be violent. If you are powerful, somehow you can be arrogant, somehow you can do whatever you feel like,” he said at a memorial gathering for Singh at the Ambedkar International Centre here. Gandhi said he doesn't believe in fighting violence with violence. So, the question arises how one responds to this and the

answer is that one should not respond with anger and hatred but one should respond by expressing oneself, by defending the idea one stands for and by showing the talent one has, he said.

Gandhi said one should respond by stating that “we are not going to accept this nonsense, we are not going to be pushed aside by this violence, we are not going to be frightened of this violence and we are all going to stand against this violence”. That to him, Gandhi said, was the best answer. In politics and life, symbols are very important and Vikram Singh is a symbol of a life that was well-lived, symbol of love and affection, he added. “We are extremely proud of him. We expect justice, we will get justice and we will not be cowed down or scared of violence,” Gandhi asserted.

“We organised this function today because this is not a single incident. This happens now all the time. Sometimes it does not end in murder, sometimes it is just an insult, sometimes it is just a threat,

sometimes it is just violence but it is happening too much in our country.

“It is happening to our brothers and sisters from the Northeast and it is happening to many different communities in this country. We stand against it, we will fight and and will defeat it,” he said.

Speaking on the occasion, former Manipur chief minister Okram Ibobi Singh said the incident was really shocking for the whole nation and especially the Northeast people.

“We are not here for politics or political gain. India attained Independence more than 70 years ago and still we are asked whether we are from Nepal or elsewhere. Manipur is a part of India. Though small in size, it is a state of India. How long can we tolerate this type of attitude towards Manipur and the Northeast,” he said. Slamming the BJP, Ibobi Singh said this party came to power and every alternate day there are killings in Manipur and like Britishers, they are using the policy of divide and rule.

Two Nihangs held for sword attack over bill dispute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two Nihang Sikh brothers were apprehended after one of them allegedly attacked a sugarcane juice shop worker with a sword following a dispute over bill payment at the New Delhi Railway Station, police said.

The incident took place at around 10 am near a sugarcane juice shop located close to the outer gate of the railway station.

“The victim, a 35-year-old shop worker, sustained a deep cut injury on his left hand just above the wrist during the altercation,” police said in a statement. The PCR staff immediately shifted him to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash (LNJP) Hospital. The two accused, identified as Gagandeep Singh (21) and his brother Baljeet Singh (30), both residents of

Jalandhar in Punjab, were apprehended at the spot by locals, police said.

According to the preliminary enquiry, the two brothers had travelled from Amritsar to Delhi by train and stayed overnight at Gurudwara Sis Ganj Sahib.

They then reached the New Delhi Railway Station to board a train to Nanded in Maharashtra for a religious visit. “The duo had stopped at the sugarcane juice shop and consumed two glasses of juice. A dispute broke out when the shop worker asked them to pay ₹60, while they insisted on paying ₹50,” read the statement. The argument soon escalated into a quarrel. During the altercation, Gagandeep Singh allegedly took out a sword and attacked the shop worker, resulting in a deep lacerated wound on his left hand.

ABVP files nomination papers for DUSU election

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The ABVP on Thursday filed nomination papers for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections, with the student organisation stepping up its outreach campaign across the university ahead of the polls.

Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad's (ABVP) probable candidates Alok Attri, Ishu Maurya, Lakshya Raj Singh, Nitin Tanwar, Riya Chhawari, Tanya Mavi and Yash Dabas filed their nomination papers, the organisation said in a statement. The final candidates for the posts of president, vice-president, secretary and joint secretary will be selected from among the probable candidates following scrutiny, it said. The organisation has also intensified its “PG-to-PG” and “class-to-class” outreach campaigns, under which its members are meeting stu-



dents to understand their concerns and suggestions. Student safety and accommodation have emerged as key issues for the organisation in the wake of the recent Satya Niketan building collapse. Under its “Aakhir Kab Tak?” campaign, the ABVP is conducting a survey of PG accommodations to identify concerns related to safety and basic facilities. The organisation has

demanded adequate and affordable hostel facilities, expediting the construction of new hostels and strict implementation of safety standards in PGs and rented accommodations in areas with a high concentration of students. The ABVP also highlighted initiatives it claimed were undertaken by its members in the DUSU, including installation of more than 1,000 CCTV cameras,

the Student Facility Centre, the DUSU internship initiative, increase in PG seats, reduction in evaluation fees, and the “Madari” (street theatre and cultural festival), “Campus Kalakar” (talent and fine arts initiative) and Pink Booth initiatives. “The suggestions received during the outreach campaign will form the basis of ABVP's upcoming election manifesto,” it said.

ABVP Delhi secretary Sarthak Sharma said the DUSU was “not merely an electoral platform” but a responsibility towards Delhi University students. Sharma said the organisation would incorporate issues and suggestions emerging from interactions with students into its manifesto, with a focus on building a safer and more accessible campus environment. The DUSU elections are scheduled to be held on September 18, with counting of votes to take place on September 19.

Bihar Govt transfers ₹1,233cr as part of social security pension

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Thursday transferred over ₹1,233 crore directly to the bank accounts of 1.05 crore social security pensioners in the state.

Each beneficiary, including senior citizens, widows and persons with disabilities, gets ₹1,100 through direct benefit transfer, officials said.

“The CM transferred ₹1,233.87 crore through DBT to the bank accounts of 1.05 crore social security pensioners at a function in Munger,” an official said. As many as 98,896 new beneficiaries were added to the scheme, he said. While speaking on the occasion, the CM said social security pension would be transferred directly to beneficia-



ries' bank accounts through DBT on the 10th of every month.

Choudhary said the government was committed to ensuring that eligible people receive social security benefits without discrimination and that welfare schemes reach beneficiaries directly.

The CM also laid the foundation stone for the widening and strengthening of a stretch of National Highway 333 from Gangta in Munger to Kodwarva in Jamui.

Bangladesh PM Rahman to skip BRICS Summit

BIMSTEC's participation is also important because the regional grouping connects countries around the Bay of Bengal and provides a platform for cooperation on trade, connectivity, security and economic development.

Rahman's absence from the summit would mean that his first India visit as prime minister will likely have to be arranged separately through diplomatic channels.

For now, Dhaka appears focused on ensuring that any visit by Rahman to India takes place under conditions suitable for substantive bilateral discussions. The timing of such a visit has not been finalised, and both governments are expected to remain engaged through diplomatic channels. The latest clarification therefore puts to rest, at least for the moment, speculation that Rahman's first India trip would coincide with the BRICS Summit in New Delhi.

Wangchuk warns of fresh Ladakh stir

Referring to the sub-committee meeting, Wangchuk said, “We are somewhat disappointed. Although the meeting took place in a very cordial atmosphere, nothing concrete emerged from it. All that transpired was a reiteration of the decisions made four months ago. We felt that the meeting on 9 September was merely a tactic to buy time and to defer the major <padayatra></i> in Ladakh, originally scheduled on 10 September. We would wait for one week to receive an assurance that no major decisions affecting Ladakh would be taken until a democratic structure is established there. Until then, the UT administration must halt efforts to alter the very character and landscape of Ladakh, and the region's legitimate democratic framework must be restored. They should work in collaboration with that body; if they unilaterally change everything beforehand, what role would be left for the future elected Assembly...”

Meanwhile, in Leh, Kundra said the Union Government and Ladakh leadership had agreed to work towards a “sui generis” model that would provide an elected body with legislative, executive and financial powers. “October is not very far away. Ten days of September have already passed,” Kundra said, urging the leaders to provide their responses to the questions at the earliest so that the drafting process could move ahead. Addressing a press conference in Leh on Thursday, he said the discussions had moved forward on the proposal to create a UT-level elected body under a special constitutional framework for Ladakh. He said the representatives of LAB and KDA had agreed that elections to the proposed UT-level body should be held directly through constituencies rather than indirectly through the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (LAHDCs).

He maintained the Government did not want to impose any model on Ladakh that was not acceptable to its people.

“Before preparing a document, there has to be agreement on the principles. Legal drafting of

the Bill will follow once there is agreement on those principles,” he added.

The chief secretary said the ongoing dialogue was aimed at addressing the core aspirations of the people of Ladakh, including protection of land, culture, heritage, mineral resources, environment and employment.

“This is a constitutional amendment. It requires extensive legal drafting, but before that drafting can happen, agreement on the principles is necessary,” he said. Kundra also clarified that the proposed arrangement would not amount to restoration of Statehood for Ladakh.

“Ladakh was never a State. First of all, it was part of the (erstwhile) state of Jammu and Kashmir and later became a Union Territory,” he said. “It will not be a State, and it will not be a UT with a legislature in the conventional sense. It will be some other kind of body which will have these powers,” he said, adding that the nomenclature of the proposed body had not yet been finalised. Kundra said the current proposal had emerged after the original demand for inclusion of Ladakh under the Sixth Schedule was discussed with the Union Government.

“It was subsequently explained that this model has its limitations. Therefore, the Union Government is willing to go ahead and offer something more. That ‘more’ is coming through Article 371,” he said.

He said constitutional safeguards under Article 371, once incorporated, would be difficult to alter without another constitutional amendment. However, several issues relating to the powers and functioning of the proposed body remain to be settled, he said.

“There are certain questions regarding the relationship between the LAHDCs and the UT-level body, what powers will come under the jurisdiction of the LAHDCs and what powers will come under the UT-level body,” Kundra said.

He said a list of around 8-10 questions had been shared with the leaders who attended the meeting and they had been asked to deliberate on them, consult among themselves and with the people and convey their views to the Centre. “The Ministry of Home Affairs has already started working on it. As I said, we have given them a set of questions. Through you, I would request that we receive the answers to those questions as soon as possible so that we can forward them to the Ministry of Home Affairs,” Kundra said.

He said the next meeting between the centre and Ladakh representatives would be held in the first half of October, to move towards a draft after consensus was reached on the basic principles.

On the demand for a draft before the October meeting, Kundra appealed for patience, saying the Centre wanted to ensure that the final arrangement emerged through consultation.

“If we rush into something and later realise that it was not correct, changing it becomes difficult,” he said.

On the September 24 incident last year, Kundra said cases identified for withdrawal would be sent to the Lieutenant Governor, while a proposal on compensation would also be forwarded for his consideration.

FROM PAGE - 3 Connaught place open, but Delhi braces for...

On Thursday, the traffic police clarified that Delhi will not be shut down during the summit, but commuters should brace for temporary traffic stoppages, diversions and restrictions on routes used by VVIP convoys, with the duration of such disruptions depending on security requirements and the movement of dignitaries.

In this backdrop, the New Delhi Traders Association (NDTA) on Thursday said the most popular Connaught Place market will remain open during the BRICS summit in Delhi from September 11 to 13, even as traffic restrictions are expected to affect movement in parts of the city.

NDTA joint Secretary Amit Gupta said the market has not been closed and Delhi residents can continue to shop and dine at Connaught Place during regular market hours.

Several bustling markets associations are in a fix. On the one hand the owners apprehend low footfalls due to restrictions, on the other hand closing down their establishments will lead to financial losses. The Delhi Metro Museum at Supreme Court Metro Station will remain closed from September 11 to 13, DMRC said in a post on social media. The museum will reopen on September 15, as September 14 is its weekly holiday, it said.

As regards the cricket match, the Delhi Traffic Police has asked the Delhi and District Cricket Association (DDCA) to reschedule the India-Afghanistan, citing the extensive traffic and security arrangements required for the 18th BRICS Summit. The traffic police said areas around the Arun Jaitley Stadium, DDU Marg, BSZ Marg, Minto Road, Kamla Market and adjoining roads already witness substantial vehicular and pedestrian movement.

The move, according to the traffic police, would facilitate effective deployment of resources and ensure smooth and secure movement of foreign delegates, VVIPs and the general public.

Red Fort blast accused's device held jihadist...

Referring to *Lone Mujahid Pocket Book*, chargesheet claims, “This document is a very high-risk extremist operational manual, designed to enable and inspire lone-wolf terrorist attacks and suicidal attacks through simplified, low-cost, and easily executable methods targeting innocent civilians and infrastructure.”

Referring to yet another PDF file titled *Barood, Book, Fidayi, Force* the chargesheet claims, “The document is an extremist-linked instructional manual that presents a structured overview of explosives, including classifications, properties, components, operational and general usage concepts, indicative of material intended for training and indoctrination purposes.”

Referring to yet another document titled *44 Ways Of Supporting Jihad* by Anwar Al-Awlaki, who was a proscribed terrorist, al-Qaida propagandist and recruiter, the chargesheet claims, “This document is a guide that pushes people toward extreme and violent ideas. It encourages people to join in fighting and promotes the idea

of becoming a martyr, even encouraging people to seek death”. Another document titled “Anwar Al-Awlaki - Constants on The Path of Jihad” shows supports violence without responsibility or accountability and Encourages people to travel, get training, and join fights”.

The charge sheet said that there is a document which is practical instructional manual detailing the preparation, processing, and enhancement of urea nitrate explosive material. It is instructional and operational manual enabling manufacture of explosive material using accessible resources such as nitric acid, aluminium powder, ammonium nitrate and urine as source of urea. The expert clearly mentioned that this document gives easy instructions on how to make and produce explosives. It acts as a practical step-by-step manual that teaches exactly how to manufacture explosives. It specifically provides clear, actionable guidance on preparing and improving urea nitrate explosives, and explains how to use them to build improvised explosive devices (IEDs). This document suggests that the reader is prepared to carry out an attack and nurtures intent to make explosive substances.

“Another document advocates armed Jihad and rule of caliphate and discusses at length about Al-Qaida, Taliban, ISIS and further speaks against existing political systems i.e. democracy, which mentions that ‘Muslims cannot attain honour without Jihad’, ‘perpetual armed struggle as religious duty’, ‘Satanic and tyrannical systems collapse through the blessed act of Jihad’ etc. In brief the document justifies violence in the name of Islam for Gazwa-e-Hind and praises global Armed Jihad in the countries viz. Iraq, Afghanistan, America,” the charge sheet said.

According to the charge sheet, there is one document in the digital device seized in the case which is titled ‘Message to the Muslims of Kashmir’ which contains the topics viz. offering heartfelt condolences to those who lost their lives in armed Jihad in Kashmir, honours the courage and sacrifice of the Mujahideen, comforts and congratulates the families and parents of those killed in armed Jihad and the expert is of the view that in this document the man shamelessly congratulates the families and parents of those misguided youth who lost their lives in waging war against India in Kashmir with de-contextualisation of Quranic verses.

CBI nabs Indian fugitive after US deportation

The investigation found that in 2013, fraudsters in India made fake phone calls to Indian citizens in Singapore. They pretended to be officials from Singapore immigration department. They tricked the victims into believing there were mistakes in their airport disembarkation forms, which could lead to criminal charges or deportation, and into paying supposed settlement fees or fines. They sent the money via Western Union Money Transfer to predetermined recipients in India. The stolen funds were received through a money-transfer business run by Harnek Singh in association with the co-accused Aditya Bhardwaj and Deepak Jain. Singh left India in May 2013 and then entered the US illegally, where he

had been living as a fugitive for over ten years.

During the time that Singh was outside the jurisdiction of the Indian courts, the trial concerning Aditya Bhardwaj from Gurugram continued in Panchkula. The court found both guilty and sentenced them to two and a half years in prison, along with fines.

Earlier, the court had separated Singh's case because he was missing. The evidence included digital records, financial transaction trails, forensic analysis of forged Western Union forms, and testimony from many witnesses. Counterfeit identification documents had been used to withdraw the funds. As regards international pursuit and legal action, although a summons and a bailable warrant were served on Singh in the US by the US Department of Justice, he did not turn up before the trial court.

As a result, the Special Judicial Magistrate of the CBI in Panchkula issued an open-ended arrest warrant. The CBI then used the Interpol system, which led to a Red Notice. They also started a Look-Out Circular for his passport. With help from foreign authorities, this eventually led to his deportation from the US.

Racist US Govt ad targets Indians, sparks row

Another post features Optimus Prime, the main protagonist in the Transformers franchise, with a DHS arm patch confronting the brown-bearded man with the message: “Self-deport or find out.” The reference to “Mr Singh” in the advertisement was criticised by advocacy groups, including the Hindu American Foundation and Sikh Coalition. “Sings are Hindu, they are Sikhs, they are American and they drive. Racist, anti-American, anti-Indian profiling/trolling by @DHSgov should shock our nation's collective conscience,” Hindu American Foundation (HAF) said in a post on X.

“This is a discriminatory post by a federal agency that is far beyond political messaging, and we welcome an investigation,” the HAF said, tagging Assistant Attorney General Harmeet K Dhillon and FBI Director Kash Patel.

“Enforce the law. Do not caricature a people. @DHSgov Dangerous drivers come from all backgrounds, ethnicities, faiths and last names,” Coalition of Hindus of North America (COHNA) said. “Singling out SOME last names does nothing for safe streets, but it does endanger the safety of hundreds of thousands of Americans with names like Singh and Kumar,” the group said.

“Twenty-five years after 9/11, Sikhs are still being targeted and profiled for how we look,” the Sikh Coalition said in a post on X.

“Millions of Sikhs in the United States have the last name Singh, which means lion. We remain fearless in identifying as Sikhs - even when our government portrays us as enemies,” the Sikh Coalition said.

The row comes amid a DHS campaign to promote its CBP Home programme, which allows eligible undocumented migrants to register their intention to leave the United States voluntarily. Those registering for self-deportation can receive travel assistance and an exit bonus of \$2,600, according to the DHS. (PTI)

15,000 cops, 500 cameras: Delhi on BRICS alert

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Two days out, and Bharat Mandapam already looks like a city expecting company it does not entirely trust yet, lit up in decorative gold at night, ringed by barricades by day, watched over by more cameras than most of Delhi's residents will ever notice. The 18th BRICS Summit opens here on September 12 and 13, and the ground report is unambiguous: this is a capital in its final, most anxious hours of preparation.

Delhi Police has deployed around 15,000 personnel and nearly 200 companies of paramilitary forces for the security exercise, according to officials, covering Bharat Mandapam itself, Indira Gandhi International Airport,

the hotels housing visiting dignitaries, and every route official motorcades are expected to use. Summit-related programmes and delegate movements begin on September 11, with the full traffic and security architecture in place from September 11 through 13.

Around Bharat Mandapam, the visible layer of that architecture is cameras. Over 500 CCTV units have been installed across the area, according to a security official. "With these arrangements in place, we have covered all roads in the area. If we notice anything suspicious, we can take action within seconds and secure the entire area," the official said. Number plate recognition cameras have also been rolled out across New Delhi district, layered onto fresh

banners and upgraded night lighting meant to double as both a security tool and a welcome mat.

New Delhi DCP Sachin Sharma, speaking to reporters as arrivals began on Thursday, said the district was fully prepared. "We have made elaborate arrangements regarding all the aspects of law and order, security, and an anti-terror point of view," Sharma said, adding that multiple rounds of briefings had been conducted, staff deployed, and senior officers were carrying out point-wise checks across the district.

Security preparations earlier in the week included full motorcade rehearsals, with Delhi Police running through VVIP routes and reviewing arrangements across the capital, a drill that



Security personnel are deployed in front of Bharat Mandapam ahead of BRICS Summit, in New Delhi PANKAJ KUMAR

briefly diverted traffic at 22 locations across the city. Security has also been strengthened across the NDMC area, while police said arrangements along the Yamuna are being reviewed,

with a vigilant watch being maintained from Purana Qila as part of the wider security perimeter.

At the airport, the preparations are running on a parallel clock. IGI Airport is expect-

ed to handle an additional 40 to 50 flights linked to the summit through the weekend and into Monday morning, as delegations arrive on chartered and scheduled aircraft. Air traffic control staffing has

been strengthened to coordinate dignitary movements alongside regular commercial operations, while some special aircraft are being routed through the Palam technical area to ease pressure on the main terminal. Authorities have also inspected the approach roads connecting the airport to diplomatic hotels and central Delhi, effectively stitching together a security corridor that runs from the runway to Bharat Mandapam's front gate.

Away from the barricades, the city's cosmetic preparations continue in parallel. The New Delhi Municipal Council has been carrying out road repairs, refreshed kerbs, freshly marked zebra crossings, upgraded footpaths and thematic street paintings across major stretches of New Delhi, part

of a broader beautification push that, as reported earlier this week, has also placed more than 15,000 potted plants and floral installations along the routes BRICS delegates are expected to travel.

The scale of the operation reflects what officials describe as the summit's core objective, ensuring that leaders from BRICS member and partner countries, outreach nations and international organisations can move through the capital without disruption or incident. For ordinary Delhi residents, that objective is translating into a more immediate reality: traffic advisories, diversions and a city visibly bracing itself, one CCTV pole and one freshly painted zebra crossing at a time, for the two days when the world's attention turns to Bharat Mandapam.

No shutdown, traffic curbs likely

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi will not be shut down during the BRICS Summit 2026, but commuters should brace for temporary traffic stoppages, diversions and restrictions on routes used by VVIP convoys, with the duration of such disruptions depending on security requirements and the movement of dignitaries, the Delhi Traffic Police said on Thursday.

The clarification came as the traffic police issued a detailed advisory ahead of the September 12-13 summit at Bharat Mandapam. Traffic restrictions linked to the movement of foreign delegations and dignitaries are expected to remain in force from September 10 to around September 14, officials said. The traffic police said restrictions would be imposed in notified "controlled areas" and on routes being used for VIP movement, but normal traffic would continue wherever security arrangements permit. Residents living in controlled areas will be allowed to move subject to security arrangements and have been advised to carry valid identification and address proof and follow instructions from the police personnel deployed there.

There is no fixed duration for traffic stoppages during VIP movement, the police said. Traffic may be temporarily halted or diverted depending on security requirements and the prevailing ground situation, after which vehicles would be released in phases.

Traffic was regulated at 22 diversion points during the rehearsal between 7 pm and 10 pm, while more than 35 roads are expected to be affected during the summit period. Key roads likely to see restrictions include Mathura Road, Sardar Patel Marg, Shanti Path, Janpath,



Ashoka Road, Barakhamba Road, Tolstoy Marg, Africa Avenue Road, Niti Marg, Panchsheel Marg and APJ Abdul Kalam Road.

The impact is expected to be particularly pronounced for commuters travelling between Noida and central Delhi, east Delhi and central areas, as well as those travelling from Dwarka and west Delhi towards Dhaula Kuan, the airport and south Delhi. The Egyptian delegation's movement between its hotel in Saket and central Delhi could put additional pressure on already congested stretches of south Delhi, particularly during peak hours. Traffic police had earlier flagged the issue and suggested shifting the delegation's accommodation to central Delhi.

Officials said the scale of the summit should also be taken into account while assessing traffic disruptions, with India hosting leaders from 11 BRICS member countries and 10 partner nations, besides other invited delegations. A visiting leader's schedule can involve multiple high-security movements in a day — from the airport to the hotel, the hotel to the summit venue and then to bilateral meetings, official events or other engagements. What may appear to be a few VIP movements can therefore add up to around 70-80 or more high-security movements across the city in a single day,

officials said. Each such movement requires separate traffic regulation, access restrictions and route coordination, making the impact on commuters significantly larger than during an ordinary VIP visit, they said.

Candidates appearing for UPSC, NDA, CDS and other examinations have been advised to check their examination centres and routes beforehand, carry their admit cards and identification and leave sufficiently early. People travelling to hospitals for planned appointments have also been advised to allow additional time and check their routes beforehand.

The Delhi Metro will continue to operate, although temporary restrictions may be imposed at some stations or entry and exit gates if required due to security considerations. DTC and city buses will also operate, but routes passing through affected areas may be diverted, curtailed or regulated. Inter-state buses may also face temporary changes in routes, entry points or termination points.

Autos, taxis and app-based cab services will continue to operate, but their movement into controlled or restricted areas and their pick-up and drop-off arrangements may be affected. Delivery services may similarly face restrictions in controlled areas.

India and Afghanistan opener to proceed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The T20 series opener between India and Afghanistan will go ahead as scheduled, the Delhi and District Cricket Association (DDCA) said on Thursday, despite Delhi Traffic Police's request to reschedule the game due to the high-profile BRICS Summit.

Afghanistan will be 'hosting' India for the three-match series at the Arun Jaitley Stadium with the matches slated to be played on September 13, 15 and 17. "India-Afghanistan 1st T20I on 13 September at Arun Jaitley Stadium will go ahead as scheduled," DDCA wrote on X.

"Following a meeting with Delhi Traffic Police, DDCA has been assured of all necessary support and arrangements. No postponement," it added. Earlier, the Delhi Traffic Police had asked the DDCA to reschedule the opening match citing extensive traffic and security arrangements in place for the BRICS Summit over the weekend. In a letter dated September 9 to the DDCA secretary, the DCP traffic (central range), said a large number of foreign delegates, dignitaries and VVIPs are expected to visit Delhi for the summit, scheduled on September 12 and 13.

The letter said the summit would require extensive traffic arrangements, including VVIP/VIP route regulation, traffic diversions, route clearance and deployment of personnel for the smooth movement of foreign delegates and associated vehicles. The match is expected to attract approximately 25,000 to 35,000 spectators, according to the letter.

NDMC lights up 17 roundabouts, 11 hotels

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has undertaken extensive decorative illumination across its jurisdiction ahead of the BRICS Summit 2026, lighting up 17 major roundabouts, 11 hotel premises and 10 prominent NDMC buildings. The light work gives the national Capital a vibrant, world-class appearance for visiting delegates.

According to NDMC, the illumination works aim to give key locations a distinctive and elegant look reflecting the grandeur of the summit, with lighting arrangements executed for aesthetics, uniformity and energy efficiency across major landmarks, roads and public spaces.

For roundabout beautification, NDMC installed uplighters, LED strings and other illumination on trees, shrubs and landscaped areas



at locations including Patel Chowk, Windsor Place, Mandi House, Shantipath-Kautilya, Shantipath-Panchsheel, Shantipath-Satya Marg, RML, Teen Murti, Q-Point, Claridges Hotel, Samrat Hotel, Ashoka Hotel, Methi, Lok Kalyan Metro Station, Man Singh, York Place and PM Roundabout.

Areas surrounding major hotels were similarly illuminated, with decorative lighting installed on trees along roads around Hotel Taj Palace, ITC Maurya, Ashoka

Hotel, Samrat Hotel, The Leela Hotel, Taj Mansingh, Claridges Hotel, Shangri-La Hotel, Le Meridien Hotel, The Imperial Hotel and one additional identified hotel premises.

To reinforce the summit's visual identity across the city, NDMC installed LED signages displaying the BRICS Summit logo on street-light poles along important avenue roads connecting the airport and designated hotels to Bharat Mandapam, the summit venue. BRICS Summit posters were also placed on

road-light pillars along the same routes, creating a uniform thematic appearance for delegates travelling between these key points.

Among NDMC buildings and sites receiving decorative illumination are Palika Kendra, NDCC Phase-II, Convention Centre, Chandralok Building, Ashirwad Old Age Home, Charakha Museum, Central Park and Palika Bazaar area, AAV Mandir Marg, Lok Nayak Bhawan and Chanakya Bhawan.

NDMC also completed a 100 percent verification of streetlights along all summit-related routes, replacing every faulty light identified during the exercise to ensure improved illumination during the event. Additionally, around 350 electrical panel boxes installed along roads in the NDMC area received a facelift through flex sticker branding, enhancing the overall appearance of major roads across New Delhi.

More than 100 artistes to perform at BRICS dinner

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An ensemble of over 100 artistes drawn largely from India as well as other member countries of BRICS is set to perform at a gala dinner that Prime Minister Narendra Modi will host for various world leaders on the opening day of the grouping's Summit at the Bharat Mandapam.

India is hosting the BRICS Summit at the sprawling venue in central Delhi on September 12-13, which will be attended by Chinese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin and several other heads of state, among other top dignitaries. "A large group of artistes — classical dancers and musicians, largely from India, as well as musicians from various other member countries of BRICS, will showcase 'BRICS Symphony' during the gala dinner that the prime minister will host for the invited leaders on September 12, the day the Summit opens, at the Bharat Mandapam," a person familiar with the matter said.

The size of the ensemble would be about 160, with Indian dancers and musi-



cians forming the core of the performance troupe, they said. Indian dancers will perform classical dances such as Bharatnatyam, Kuchipudi, Odissi and Kathak representing different regions of India, while musicians will play traditional instruments of the country, complemented by musicians from some of the other member countries of the grouping, according to the plan, one of the persons cited above said.

The show's duration would be about 20-25 minutes and there will be intermittent vocal renditions, the person added.

The Indian team members of the ensemble have been rehearsing for the perfor-

mance in the past two days, ahead of the big day. The planned show is being helmed by the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR), the cultural arm of the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), they added.

India is a founding member of the BRICS and has previously held its chairship three times — in 2012, 2016 and 2021. The country assumed its fourth BRICS chairship on January 1, and has since then hosted a large number of meetings under various thematic tracks such as finance, environment, diplomacy, law, culture and tourism.

India hosted the BRICS Foreign Ministers' Meeting on May 14-15, chaired by External Affairs Minister S

Jaishankar. Under the theme 'Samavay', the ICCR had welcomed guests at the BRICS cultural performance and gala dinner hosted by Jaishankar on May 14 at the Bharat Mandapam.

The evening resonated with the melodies of India's devotional traditions, the grace of Bharatanatyam, and the vibrant energy of folk dances from across India.

Besides, a special mural is also being created at the Bharat Mandapam. The art as well as the musical projects represent the cultural exchange and bonds that exist among BRICS members, with India being the host for the 18th BRICS Summit, the person familiar with the matter added.

As part of their cultural experience, the artists visited Agra, where they explored the iconic Taj Mahal and Agra Fort, and went to an embroidery and traditional handicraft centre, witnessing a live demonstration of Zardozi embroidery and traditional craftsmanship, along with an experience of Indian classical music, offering them an enriching glimpse into India's heritage and living artistic traditions, it said.



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CBI books Ozone, Vivansaa in homebuyer fraud; raids 12 sites

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi / Bengaluru

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Thursday registered five new criminal cases against real-estate developers and unidentified officials of financial institutions, and searched 12 locations in Bengaluru, Mumbai and Pune, in the Supreme Court-monitored probe into alleged cheating of homebuyers.

Four cases have been registered against Ozone Group and related entities over projects in Bengaluru and Mumbai. The fifth case names M/s Vivansaa Baalsam for its Bengaluru project. Unknown bank and housing-finance officials have also been named. The Bengaluru cases against Ozone relate to the group's large integrated township at Kannamangala in Devanahalli taluk, near Kempegowda International Airport. The development, marketed as Ozone Urbana, includes residential components such as Ozone Urbana Avenue, Ozone Urbana Aqua and Aqua 2.

The township was launched more than a decade ago as an 1,800-unit project



spread over about 185 acres, with possession originally projected around 2018. Buyers have alleged incomplete construction, delayed handover, subvention-scheme defaults and, in some instances, multiple allotments of the same unit. The Mumbai cases concern Ozone Group projects in the city, including Ozone The Autograph at Wadala.

The group also has other Mumbai developments such as Ozone The Gateway in Andheri West and Ozone Mirabilis in Santacruz East, which investigators are examining as part of the alleged builder-lender nexus. The Vivansaa case relates to Vivansaa Baalsam, a residen-

tial project on Sarjapur-Attibele Road in S. Medahalli, Bengaluru, offering apartments and villas.

Buyers had approached the Supreme Court alleging fraud and financial irregularity in the project. The five cases allege criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust and criminal misconduct by officials of financial institutions.

CBI said the complaints point to developers collecting buyer and loan funds against promises of timely possession, often under "no pre-EMI till handover" schemes. Meanwhile, lenders continued disbursements and later pressed buyers for repayment even after construc-

tion stalled. Searches on Thursday covered offices and other premises linked to these projects. Documents, digital devices and other material were seized and are under examination.

The agency said the operation aims to trace alleged diversion of project receipts, irregular lending and fraudulent practices. CBI had earlier registered 50 cases against builders on the Court's orders. With Thursday's action, the total stands at 55. Ozone Urbana Infra Developers had already been named in an earlier CBI case and chargesheet over a Bengaluru housing project.

In August, the Supreme Court directed a thorough probe into additional representations on Ozone Group projects in Karnataka, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu, and Vivansaa in Bengaluru. Case registration and searches do not establish guilt. Authorities will analyse the seized records before taking further legal steps. For affected buyers in Ozone Urbana, The Autograph and Vivansaa Baalsam, the criminal inquiry runs alongside separate claims for possession, refund or compensation.

Fresh threat letter targets PM package employees in Kashmir



MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

A fresh threat letter, the sixth in the last 40 days, targeting Prime Minister's Package employees in Jammu and Kashmir, featuring photographs of protesting staff and an image of an AK-47, has once again created a flutter in the security establishment in the Kashmir valley.

The communication, dated September 10 and attributed to an outfit calling itself the United Liberation Council (ULC), has once again attempted to intimidate the PM Package employees. Speaking on behalf of affected employees, Rakesh Handoo, in a post on X, said that the PM Package employees had faced repeated threats in recent weeks, but no arrests have been made so far.

He said the latest message had raised the intimidation to a new level by using photographs of employees who had recently protested for safer accommodation and security. Some of those images, he said, were of staff whose interviews had been shown on television a day earlier.

The threat letter branded PM Package employees "white-collar terrorist migrant Pandits" and "MHA-backed protesters," claimed to possess details of their whereabouts, families and daily movements, and warned that they could be struck "at will."

"This is not merely a threat

on paper. When photographs of employees are circulated with a gun image and the perpetrators claim to possess information about their whereabouts, families and daily activities, it raises extremely serious questions about their safety and the possible misuse of personal data," Handoo said. He urged the Jammu and Kashmir Police and other security agencies to take immediate cognisance of the communication, register a case under relevant law and identify those behind it. He also called for an immediate security assessment of employees whose photographs appeared in the message.

"The government must urgently assess the threat perception of these employees and take whatever security measures are necessary to protect them. Waiting for an actual attack before acting would be a grave mistake," he said.

Handoo sought a thorough inquiry into the alleged circulation of personal information of PM Package employees on social media and other digital platforms. "If individuals with terror links are claiming to possess phone numbers, addresses, family details, movements and other personal information of employees, the source of this information must be investigated. Any unauthorised access, leakage or circulation of such data cannot be ignored," he said.

Prince Rahim Aga Khan V, PM discuss development partnership

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prince Rahim Aga Khan V, 50th Imam of the Ismaili Muslims, held discussions with Prime Minister Narendra Modi here on Thursday on India's partnership with the Aga Khan Development Network (AKDN) in agriculture and rural development, among other areas.

Prince Rahim Aga Khan V is visiting India from September 9 to 15 following an invitation from Vice President CP Radhakrishnan.

"Happy to meet His Highness Prince Rahim Aga Khan V. Fondly recalled his father, the late Aga Khan IV and his enduring contribu-



tions to development efforts. Discussed ways to further strengthen our partnership with the Aga Khan Development Network in healthcare, agriculture, rural development, youth and women empowerment," Modi said in a post on social media.

Prince Rahim Aga Khan V will be visiting Ahmedabad,

Mumbai and Hyderabad, where the AKDN is involved in various development and community initiatives. This is his first visit to India since his accession as the 50th Imam of the Ismaili community.

Vice President Radhakrishnan and Prince Rahim Aga Khan discussed further strengthening coop-

eration between India and the network in sectors such as sports and education.

In a social media post, the Vice President Secretariat said both leaders reaffirmed the need to eradicate radicalisation and underscored that dialogue remains the path to peace, stability and shared prosperity. The 50th hereditary Imam of the Ismaili Community met Radhakrishnan at the Vice President's Enclave here.

The two leaders discussed the Aga Khan Development Network's contributions to water and sanitation, women-led self-help groups, education and community development, and appreciated its impactful initiatives in East Africa and Afghanistan.

Karnataka Govt orders singing of only two Vande Mataram stanzas at State programmes



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Congress government in Karnataka has ordered that only the first 2 stanzas of Vande Mataram be sung at its programmes, except those attended by the president, vice-president, prime minister or governor.

The order follows a decision taken by the state Cabinet on the playing or singing of Vande Mataram at government programmes and functions held in the state. In January, the Union Home Ministry directed that all 6 stanzas of Vande Mataram be sung before the National Anthem, Jana Gana Mana, when both are played together. The directive was issued as the Centre marked the 150th year of Vande Mataram.

However, the Congress Working Committee decided on August 19 to abide by its 1937 resolution on Vande Mataram, under which only 2 stanzas of the National Song would be sung at party events.

The decision came after the BJP accused Congress leaders of insulting Vande Mataram by not singing its full version at party events.

during the Indian National Movement.

It said the Union Home Ministry had issued guidelines on the official version of the National Song and the protocol for singing or playing it at various government and public functions. The guidelines specify occasions for playing and mass singing of the National Song, it said.

The state government said the order aimed to ensure uniformity, dignity and adherence to appropriate protocol while singing or playing Vande Mataram at government programmes and functions in Karnataka, depending on the occasion.

"In view of the matters explained in the preamble, it is hereby ordered that, in programmes organised by the state government, only the first two stanzas of the song Vande Mataram shall be sung, except at programmes attended by the president, vice-president, prime minister and governor," the order said.

The opposition BJP in Karnataka on Thursday lashed out at the Congress government, terming the decision "appeasement politics".

Leader of Opposition in the Assembly R Ashoka said the Congress had no limits to its "appeasement politics", not even when it came to Vande Mataram.

Fortress Capital: 30,000 guards, separate hotels and sealed convoys for Xi, Putin and Pezeshkian

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The national capital has been transformed into a tightly controlled security fortress ahead of the 18th BRICS Summit, with nearly 30,000 personnel deployed across airports, hotels and the sprawling Bharat Mandapam complex as Chinese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian prepare to arrive. Security teams from China and Russia are already on the ground.

In the luxury hotels located in Chanakyapuri, where the leaders will be

lodging, security teams have been placed and armed with specialised equipment and weapons. Personnel are stationed on all floors, from the presidential suites to the roof levels and the ground floor. The routes for the convoys have been determined, traffic corridors have been closed off, and multiple layers of protection extend from Palam Air Force Station to the summit venue.

Putin is due to arrive on Friday, September 11, and Xi on Saturday, September 12; both will land at Palam and be taken under heavy escort to their respective hotels. Iranian President Pezeshkian



National flags of the various countries participating in the BRICS Summit displayed at the gate of Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

will stay at a different hotel. Each leader has a separate security team assigned.

The Delhi Police Special Cell is providing security for President Xi. At Putin's hotel, one additional deputy com-

missioner and two assistant commissioners are on rotating shifts. Half of the 30,000 personnel are from the Delhi Police, and the other half are from the paramilitary forces. The area is split into sectors,

Black SUV key to Odisha orangutan probe, 55 CCTV cameras checked

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

Odisha Police's STF and the Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB) on Thursday intensified their probe into the mystery surrounding the rescue of five baby orangutans from a forest in Balasore district and launched a search for a black SUV reportedly seen in the area.

Investigators suspect an international wildlife trafficking network could be behind the presence of the animals in the state, officials said. The forest department rescued the orangutans from Bichitrapur forest under Bhograi block on Tuesday morning.

Investigators are now focusing on a black SUV reportedly seen near Badapahi village in the area on Monday night. The STF has so far examined footage from 55 CCTV cameras installed in Bhograi and nearby Digha in West Bengal.

"We have verified the vehicles' movement on Monday night in both places, but so far there has been no breakthrough," a senior police officer said,

adding that the SUV could provide a major clue.

Forest and Environment Minister Ganesh Ram Singh Khuntia said villagers had reported seeing a black SUV in the area where the orangutans were rescued.

"The CCTV footage also confirmed that such an SUV had passed the area around 11.25 pm on Monday. But the footage could only capture the upper portion of the vehicle and not its registration number. Therefore, it is important to locate the mysterious SUV," he told reporters.

The forest department has restricted public entry to Bichitrapur forest as investigators suspect that evidence could otherwise be disturbed or destroyed, sources said.

Police have also recovered face masks from a black polythene bag in the area and suspect they may have been used by those who released the orangutans in the forest.

Local residents have denied any connection with the masks, a police official said.

Regional Chief Conservator of Forests (RCCF)



An official feeds baby orangutans, who were recently rescued from Balasore district in a quarantine cell at the Nandankanan Zoological Park, in Khordha district, Odisha

PTI

Prakash Chandra Gogineni, who is also director of the Similipal Tiger Reserve, said circumstantial evidence indicated that the animals could have been brought into Balasore from West Bengal through the Digha-Chandaneswar and Bhograi route.

"The circumstantial evidence strongly indicates that the orangutans were brought to Balasore district from West Bengal side using the Digha-Chandaneswar and Bhograi route, which passes through rural areas. The wildlife traffickers deliberately avoided national highways and instead used interior village roads to

transport the animals," he said. Based on the forest department's assessment, STF personnel examined CCTV footage from rural roads, including cameras installed at the Kalaghat toll plaza in West Bengal, an official said.

Gogineni said the presence of the animals pointed to a possible international trafficking link, as orangutans are not native to India and cannot be legally bred or kept locally.

He said the animals could have been trafficked from Myanmar through the Northeast into eastern India, taking advantage of the region's geography.

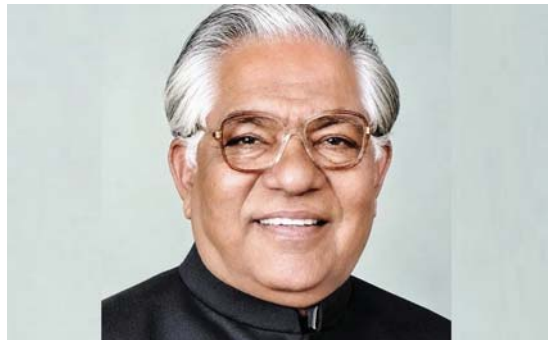
Nation Focus



INS Mysore reaches Malaysia for Naval exercise

As part of the Indian Navy's operational deployment, its ship INS Mysore arrived at Lumut, Malaysia, on Wednesday to participate in the 4th edition of the bilateral maritime exercise 'Samudra Laksamana' between the Indian Navy and the Royal Malaysian Navy, the defence ministry said here on Thursday. Exercise Samudra Laksamana comprises of professional engagements in harbour and at sea, including cross-deck visits, operational interactions and sporting engagements. These activities will provide opportunities for personnel of both navies to exchange professional experiences, enhance interoperability and foster greater mutual understanding.

Building upon the momentum generated by recent bilateral engagements, including the 12th India - Malaysia Sub Committee Meeting held in July this year, the visit underscores the strong and enduring maritime partnership between India and Malaysia and reflects the expanding scope of cooperation between the two navies. (PTI)



Former Punjab minister Bhagat Chunni Lal passes away

Former Punjab minister Bhagat Chunni Lal passed away on Thursday, his son and Cabinet minister Mohinder Bhagat said. The 93-year-old Lal breathed his last at his home in Jalandhar.

"Chunni Lal Bhagat ji is no longer with us. We are deeply saddened by his demise," Mohinder Bhagat, who is the Horticulture minister in the AAP Government, said.

His cremation will take place in Jalandhar at 5 pm on Thursday.

The Punjab Government declared a half-day holiday in view of Lal's demise.

Lal was a cabinet minister in the erstwhile SAD-BJP Government in 2012. He held the portfolios of Local Government and Medical Education and Research in the then Parkash Singh Badal Government. (PTI)

each headed by a senior officer to maintain control. The security plan includes anti-drone systems, rooftop surveillance, and secure routes, and officials say it is more comprehensive than the security arrangement at the 2023 G20 summit.

The two-day meeting of the leaders, held on September 12 and 13, takes place as the enlarged group of 11 members faces tension. Ongoing conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine, strain on energy routes, and diverging member interests have tested BRICS unity. Since it is India's turn to act as chair with the theme "Building for Resilience,

Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability", it is attempting to reach an agreement on the New Delhi Declaration while the negotiators are working on the wording concerning the Middle East conflict.

President Xi's presence is particularly important, as this is his first visit to India in seven years and is seen as a careful step toward improving relations between New Delhi and Beijing. Putin is making his second visit in less than a year, and this is Pezeshkian's first trip as Iran's president. On Friday, Putin and Pezeshkian will hold bilateral talks before the formal summit programme begins.

ODISHA WILL NOT BE ALLOWED TO BECOME ROUTE FOR WILDLIFE TRAFFICKING: CM

Bhubaneswar: Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Thursday ordered a probe into the circumstances under which five baby orangutans were brought to the state, saying Odisha will not be allowed to become a transit route for illegal wildlife trafficking.

Majhi, who is on a five-day business tour of the UAE, expressed deep concern over the rescue of the five baby orangutans from a jungle in Balasore district on Tuesday, a statement issued by the Chief Minister's Office said.

Despite his busy schedule in Dubai, the chief minister has been closely monitoring developments in Odisha and has directed officials to ascertain how the animals reached Balasore and uncover the background of the incident, it said.

Majhi has also ordered an investigation into the route used to bring the rare animals to Odisha, how they entered the state, the people involved in their transportation and the purpose for which they were brought, according to the statement.

"Odisha will never be allowed to serve as a transit route for the illegal trafficking of exotic wildlife. If any network is found to be involved in this illegal transport, it will be identified, and strict action will be taken in accordance with the law," Majhi said.

The chief minister directed the authorities concerned to investigate the matter in coordination with the Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB) and other agencies of the Centre. (PTI)



States Focus



PM MODI, GERMAN CHANCELLOR REVIEW STRATEGIC TIES

Germany is an important pillar of India's engagement with Europe and a valued partner for promoting global peace and prosperity, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Thursday after German Chancellor Friedrich Merz dialled him and they reviewed the progress of the India-Germany Strategic Partnership.

Marking 75 years of diplomatic relations this year, the two leaders noted the sustained momentum in high-level exchanges and reaffirmed their commitment to further strengthening cooperation across key domains, including trade and investment, advanced technologies, clean energy, defense, education and talent mobility. (PNS)



WEST BENGAL PASSES BILL TO TRANSFER UNIVERSITY STAFF

In a major development, the Suvendu Adhikari Government on Thursday passed a bill enabling the transfer of university teachers and non-teaching staff to other universities.

The State Assembly passed the West Bengal Universities and Colleges (Administration and Regulation) Amendment Bill 2026 by voice vote, wherein the provisions of Section 14A would enable the transfer of college and university teachers and non-teaching staff to other such institutions. During the passage of the Bill the Chief Minister said that it would strike a balance between "autonomy of the institutions and accountability of the staff towards the Government" adding the "so-called" scholars would now be transferred to newly established institutions so as to benefit the students in those colleges and universities. (PNS)

BJP calls Congress leaders *naraz fufas* over BRICS criticism

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday attacked the Congress for questioning the benefits of hosting the BRICS Summit, accusing the opposition party of being unable to "digest" India's rise on the global stage while calling its leaders *naraz fufas* (grumpy uncles) and "*dimagi naxals*". The 18th BRICS Summit will be held on September 12-13 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi. Earlier in the day, the Congress recalled how the grouping came about and India first hosted the Summit in 2012 during which the then prime minister Manmohan Singh proposed the idea of a BRICS Development Bank.

BJP national president Nitin Nabin said at a time when the BRICS Summit is about to

take place, such statements from Congress leaders are utterly shameful.

"The Congress is unable to digest India's development. Even after going to foreign lands, Rahul Gandhi and other Congress leaders have continued to humiliate India. Even today, when such a grand international event is happening in the country, they are still pained by it," Nabin told reporters in Rudrapur on the sidelines of a party event.

Hitting out at the Congress, he said the people of the country will "punish" the opposition party once again.

"Whenever the talk of the country's development and rise comes up, Congress always feels pained. But Congress will not be able to stop this country's development, because the leadership



of the country is in the hands of a strong and visionary leader like Prime Minister Narendra Modi. In the coming days, the people of the country will punish Congress once again," he said.

BJP MP and national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi also hit out at Congress leaders, calling them "dimagi Naxals" and

"naraz fufas".

He added that the comments reflect the mindset of Congress leaders who have repeatedly underestimated India's capabilities.

"These are the same people who had said that India simply could not enter the digital age, that people here were less intelligent. How would India become a

MP hooch tragedy: Death toll rises to 16; 32 hospitalised, 16 arrested

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sagar (MP)

The death toll in the Sagar hooch tragedy in Madhya Pradesh rose to 16 on Thursday after one more person died, while 32 others, including one who is seriously ill, are undergoing treatment at different hospitals, an official said.

Of the 30 persons shown as accused, 16 have been arrested and one detained, said police, even as Chief Minister Mohan Yadav has ordered a judicial probe into the incident. The spurious liquor was being brewed in Sagar district, they said.

District Collector Pratibha Pal told PTI over the phone that one more person died during treatment, raising the toll to 16, while 32 people are undergoing treatment, one of



them in serious condition.

Sagar Superintendent of Police (SP) Anurag Sujania said Ravi Lakhera, a member of a gang from Lalitpur in Uttar Pradesh, was allegedly involved in brewing the spurious liquor in the district. Sagar and Lalitpur share a substantial boundary.

Lakhera, a resident of Gangapuram Colony within the jurisdiction of the Kotwali police station in Lalitpur, is absconding, the SP said. He

originally hails from UP's Mahoba district, where his parents live, he added.

Authorities have also demolished illegal structures belonging to accused Manish Lodhi, Ashish Sahu and Chandrabhan Singh, he said. Manish and Ashish are absconding, while Chandrabhan is in police custody, the SP said.

According to the police, the victims had consumed spurious liquor falsely

labelled as 'Sagar Gold', a locally available cheap whisky. "We have unearthed the hooch factory," Sujania said, declining to share further details, citing his busy schedule. Police sources said empty bottles and labels of Sagar Gold, along with material used for brewing liquor, were recovered from the factory on Wednesday.

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Wednesday ordered a judicial inquiry into the hooch tragedy, soon after his arrival from Dubai, to ensure an impartial investigation and fix responsibilities, said officials. The CM also directed recently posted senior IAS officer Dilip Kumar to take charge of the Sagar division and also posted senior IPS officer Irshad Wali as Inspector General of the Sagar range.

CM Adhikari doubles down on Dharendra Shastri's comments on non-veg



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari distributes 'prasad' after offering prayers at the Kalighat Kali Temple on the 'Kaushiki Amavasya', in Kolkata on Thursday

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari has defended Godman Dharendra Shastri alias Bageshwar Baba for his "pakhandi" remarks against those who eat non-vegetarian food during the Durga Pujas. Speaking during a special session in Bengal Assembly, the Chief Minister on Thursday said that what Shastri had said was well within his right as a seer advising people about their religious conduct.

He said that "a saint had come to Liluah (in Howrah) and kept his views on nationalism, culture and united India ... He had only given his view and did not impose it on anyone, but there were some people who were inciting tension and some people were seen burning his posters outside the Bhawanipore Police Station ... In this regard, I am directing the Commissioner of Police of Kolkata to arrest those persons who did the mischief."

Adhikari's remarks came close on the heels of

protests being organised by the Congress party members in Bhawanipore area and many other places. The Chief Minister is an MLA from Bhawanipore seat, where he defeated former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, who is also a resident of the area.

Adhikari's brief statement in the House was greeted with loud applause from the BJP MLAs who had thus far remained tight-lipped on the issue. The Godman had, during a religious programme, asked the people to boycott those who eat non-vegetarian food during the Durga Pujas.

"Please do not mind but one thing I do not like about Bengal that many people here eat non veg even during the Durga Pujas... Those who do so are Pakhandis (hypocrites)... I will request you to boycott those who eat non-veg during the Durga Pujas," Shastri had said triggering a statewide debate with even State BJP president Samik Bhattacharya saying that Bengalis were free to eat whatever they eat.

PM urges global cooperation in space, cites ISRO's role for humanity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday exhorted the world community to choose cooperation over confrontation, sustainability over short-term gain and inclusion over exclusion. This key message came a day ahead of the two-day high-profile BRICS summit starting here on Saturday.

Backing his appeal, he cited the example of India's space programme and said the Indian Space Research Organisations's(ISRO) technologies and partnerships serve not only India, but the wider world. He also stressed that India's approach is rooted in 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' - 'One Earth, One Family, One Future', and this spirit must now travel beyond the planet.

Making these assertions

while addressing the first International Space Summit in Paris, he underlined the growing complexity of the cosmic environment and emphasised that orbits are becoming more crowded, technologies more powerful, and actors more numerous. He stressed that global partnerships must prioritize long-term sustainability over short-term gains.

He also underlined that India supports a safe, secure, and sustainable space domain anchored in international law, underlining that scientific data must serve the common good with openness and integrity. Virtually addressing the Space Summit, the Prime Minister said that the Indian Space Research Organisations's(ISRO) technologies and partnerships serve not only India, but the wider world.



He said for centuries, space inspired people's imagination and now, it shapes life on earth, from climate and crops to oceans and communities.

"We support a safe, secure, peaceful and sustainable space domain anchored in international law, dialogue and multilateral cooperation. Scientific data must serve the common good, with openness and integrity," he said. The prime minister said India's space journey reflects this philosophy and the ISRO,

which stands at the heart of this journey, has earned global admiration for its excellence and cost-effective missions. He said its capabilities serve farmers and fishermen, weather forecasting, disaster management and navigation. "More than 430 satellites from 34 countries have travelled to space aboard Indian rockets. ISRO's technologies and partnerships serve not only India, but the wider world," he said.

Modi said behind this

global trust is the dedication and hard work of generations of Indian scientists, engineers and technicians.

"Working day and night, they have built ISRO's global reputation mission by mission, success by success, and given India a place of pride among spacefaring nations," he said.

The prime minister said the Chandrayaan-3 made India the first nation to land near the lunar south pole and Aditya-L1 is unlocking the secrets of the Sun. He added that last year, an Indian astronaut visited the International Space Station.

"Looking ahead, we aim to establish an Indian space station by 2035 and send an Indian to the Moon by 2040. In all these efforts, our guiding principle has been clear: their benefits must reach all humanity," he said.

Alongside the ISRO, Modi

said, India's private space sector is also surging in a big way and the energy of enterprise is joining the excellence of ISRO.

"France has been a trusted partner since the Indian space programme began at Thumba in the 1960s. Today, our cooperation spans earth observation and advanced technologies, uniting scientific excellence with human purpose. We invite France and the world to be co-travellers in India's next space frontier," he said. The prime minister thanked French President Emmanuel Macron for inviting him to the summit. "Let the space summit in Paris send a clear message: we will explore together, innovate together and protect space together, for all humanity, and for generations to come. I convey my best wishes to all the participants," he said.

ISRO tests cryogenic engine for LVM3-M7 mission

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

ISRO on Thursday said it had successfully conducted the flight acceptance hot testing of the cryogenic engine identified for the seventh operational mission of the LVM3 launch vehicle (LVM3-M7), scheduled for the fourth quarter of 2026. The same test demonstrated the performance of a LOX Tank Pressurisation Module (LTPM) designed for the C32 stage, an upgraded cryogenic upper stage planned for India's Gaganyaan missions, it said.

The Gaganyaan project aims to demonstrate India's human spaceflight capability by carrying a 3-member crew to a 400-km orbit for a 3-day mission and safely returning them to Earth, with a landing in Indian sea waters. The test was conducted on Wednesday at the Main Engine and Stage Test Facility (MET) at the ISRO Propulsion Complex (IPRC), Mahendragiri.

LVM3, formerly known as GSLV MkIII, is ISRO's heaviest rocket and uses the CE20



cryogenic engine to power its upper stage.

"Cryogenic engines for every mission undergo hot testing as part of their acceptance for flight. To conduct hot testing of this upper-stage engine under sea-level conditions, despite its nozzle being designed for high-altitude operations, a Nozzle Protection System (NPS) was developed and previously validated through multiple qualification tests," ISRO said in a post on its website.

The NPS has reduced the time and effort involved in flight acceptance testing of cryogenic engines by enabling hot testing under sea-level conditions, thereby avoiding the need for testing under simulated high-altitude conditions, it said.

Saima Wazed resigns as WHO Regional Director after adverse internal report

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Saima Wazed, daughter of former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, has resigned as Regional Director of the World Health Organisation's South-East Asia Region, a day after the region's governing committee recommended that her appointment be terminated. Her departure follows months of scrutiny over allegations of financial fraud, academic credentials and a disputed land acquisition in Bangladesh. Wazed has denied wrongdoing.

Wazed submitted her resignation on September 9, 2026, according to a statement from the WHO. The organisation said the matter would now be brought to the attention of members of the Regional Committee for South-East Asia and the WHO Executive Board in line with its governance arrangements.

The resignation came shortly after the Regional Committee, on September 8, recommended ending Wazed's appointment as Regional Director. The WHO said that recommendation

had been due to be considered by the Executive Board.

The organisation said the proceedings had been conducted through its established internal mechanisms.

"This matter has been handled through the appropriate WHO processes in accordance with the WHO's regulatory framework," the WHO told The Pioneer, adding that the process was carried out with due regard for "fairness and due process."

"On 9 September 2026, Ms Saima Wazed resigned as Regional Director for the WHO South-East Asia Region. The resignation is being communicated to the Regional Committee and the Executive Board in accordance with WHO's governance arrangements. The previous day, the Regional Committee had recommended termination of her appointment. The matter has been handled in accordance with WHO's regulatory framework and due process. Dr Nilesh Buddha will continue as Officer-in-Charge of the Regional Office pending the appointment of a new Regional



Director," WHO statement.

The organisation also said it had taken steps to protect its interests and ensure it could continue fulfilling its mandate.

Wazed was elected to a five-year term as WHO Regional Director for South-East Asia in 2023 and began the role in early 2024. She was subsequently placed on unpaid administrative leave in July 2025 amid investigations and allegations concerning her conduct.

Bangladesh's Anti-Corruption Commission filed cases against Wazed in March 2025, accusing her of fraud and forgery. The allegations have included ques-

tions surrounding a travel expense, her educational qualifications and the acquisition of a plot of land in Bangladesh.

Wazed has rejected the allegations. In relation to a disputed travel expense of \$901 connected to travel to China, she reportedly said the issue resulted from an administrative mistake by an assistant handling routine reimbursement claims.

She has also defended her academic background, saying she holds an honorary doctorate linked to her work on autism in Bangladesh. Wazed reportedly said she had been transparent with WHO Director-General Tedros

Adhanom Ghebreyesus about the qualification.

Another issue under scrutiny has been a plot of land in Bangladesh. Wazed denied illegally acquiring the property and said it had been obtained before she joined the WHO. She also argued that she was entitled to the property under Bangladeshi legislation concerning the families of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, Bangladesh's founding leader and Hasina's father.

Her case has unfolded against a wider backdrop of legal action involving former officials and political allies of Hasina following her ouster in 2024. Hasina has since been living outside Bangladesh.

The WHO said Dr Nilesh Buddha will remain as Officer-in-Charge of the South-East Asia Regional Office while the organisation proceeds with the appointment of a new Regional Director.

Regional directors hold senior positions within the WHO and oversee the organisation's work across their respective regions, including public-health pro-

grammes, disease-response efforts and emergency coordination.

Wazed's resignation brings an end to a turbulent tenure at the regional office, while the formal process for selecting her successor is expected to determine the next leadership of WHO's South-East Asia operations.

In her resignation letter, Wazed criticised the WHO leadership and said she had lost confidence in Tedros.

"I was elected to the position of Regional Director to serve the countries in my region, which I had sincerely done," as per Saima's resignation letter.

She said the WHO's decision to keep her on leave had prevented her from carrying out her responsibilities. "Since you continue to prevent me from effectively carrying out my duties, I have lost all trust and confidence in your leadership of WHO," she wrote.

She also said that going nearly a year without remuneration had made her financial situation "untenable". "In these circumstances, I am choosing to step aside," Wazed wrote.



Editor's
TAKE

Remembering 9/11: 25 years, enduring lessons

Twenty-five years after 9/11, the enduring lesson is stark: force can disrupt extremism, but only justice and a more equitable world order can address its deeper roots

It has been twenty-five years since two aircraft struck the World Trade Center, a third hit the Pentagon, and a fourth crashed in a Pennsylvania field after passengers fought back. Nearly 3,000 people died in under two hours. The world that woke up on September 12, 2001, was irreversibly different, and much of what followed - for better and for worse - still shapes how nations approach security today. 9/11 rewrote the global rulebook. NATO invoked its collective-defence clause for the only time in its history. Airports became fortresses, intelligence agencies gained sweeping powers, and two long wars followed in Afghanistan and Iraq. A quarter of a century later, the balance sheet is sobering: military intervention degraded specific networks but also destabilised entire regions, feeding the very extremism it sought to end.

Iraq's collapse birthed ISIS. Afghanistan's twenty-year war ended with the Taliban back in power. The clearest lesson is that force alone cannot defeat an ideology. Surveillance and firepower disrupt plots, but they cannot dry up the wells - poverty, humiliation, unresolved political grievances, and the sense that international law applies selectively - from which extremist recruitment draws. This is not an excuse for terrorism; nothing justifies the deliberate killing of civilians.

But counter-terrorism that ignores root causes only postpones the next attack. Here, the case for a more equitable world order becomes practical, not idealistic. A global system in which powerful states apply human rights and sovereignty selectively, where reconstruction aid arrives only after devastation, and where bodies like the UN Security Council remain frozen since 1945, cannot credibly ask the disenfranchised to trust its rules. Reformed institutions, consistent application of international law, and sustained investment in education and development in fragile regions are not charity - they are counter-terrorism by other means.

India learned its own version of this lesson on 26/11. When ten gunmen from a Pakistan-based terror group struck Mumbai in November 2008, India discovered that its National Security Guard commandos, based near Delhi, took nearly ten hours to reach the crisis.

The response reshaped India's security architecture: NSG hubs came up in Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata and Hyderabad, and the National Investigation Agency was created.

Diplomatically, India has spent nearly two decades pressing the world to treat cross-border terror infrastructure with the same seriousness as the act of terror itself. That campaign has succeeded only partially.

The way forward demands sustained investment in de-radicalisation and development alongside intelligence and defence, and multilateral institutions reformed enough to apply their rules consistently. A world order that is fairer, more consistent and less selective in whose grievances it hears will always be the safer one.

BRICS at a crossroads

From a four-member economic acronym coined in 2001, BRICS has evolved into a powerful Global South platform spanning 11 members and 10 partners. As India hosts its 18th summit amid geopolitical conflict, trade disruptions and US pressure, the bloc faces a defining test: can it turn growing heft into meaningful outcomes?



PARUL
CHANDRA

When Goldman Sachs economist Jim O'Neill coined the acronym BRIC in 2001 to group the emerging economies of Brazil, Russia, India and China, he could hardly have envisioned its evolution into a large, influential diplomatic bloc over a quarter of a century later.

Now known as BRICS after South Africa joined it in 2010, the grouping has expanded to include 11 member states and 10 partner countries. Over the years, it has become a vital platform for emerging markets and developing economies seeking a more equitable international order and meaningful reform of global governance institutions.

The bloc's growth underscores its rising heft on the world stage. Several countries, many from the African continent, are now eager to join BRICS, which expanded considerably in 2024 with the inclusion of Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the UAE. Indonesia joined a year later alongside ten other nations - Belarus, Bolivia, Kazakhstan, Cuba, Malaysia, Nigeria, Thailand, Uganda, Uzbekistan and Vietnam — which became partner countries. Today, the 11 member states represent nearly half the world's population, 40 per cent of global GDP and 26 per cent of international trade.

As a founding member of the informal grouping, India, as the current Chair, will host the BRICS Summit on September 12-13 in New Delhi. It is for the fourth time that India will be hosting the Summit. For India, its BRICS membership is in consonance with its commitment to multilateralism and its policy of strategic autonomy. It also allows India to highlight the need for global governance reform.

Importantly, the Summit will also offer New Delhi the opportunity to demonstrate its diplomatic clout by convening a meeting of world leaders and for Prime Minister Narendra Modi to have bilateral meetings with them on the sidelines.

The upcoming Summit, the 18th, is particularly significant as it is taking place against the backdrop of severe geopolitical friction, economic uncertainty, and trade and supply chain disruptions. The long-drawn Russia-Ukraine conflict and the US-Israel war with Iran have contributed in no small measure to the economic headwinds buffeting the world. The West Asia conflict, which has led to the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz and enveloped other countries in the region in



BRICS DOES NEED TO DELIVER SUBSTANTIVE OUTCOMES AND PUT ITS MONEY WHERE ITS MOUTH IS. INDEED, EXTERNAL AFFAIRS MINISTER DR S. JAISHANKAR SAID IN MAY THIS YEAR ABOUT BRICS, “OUR RELEVANCE WILL DEPEND ON OUTCOMES, NOT JUST ON INTENT

The writer is a policy analyst who writes on foreign affairs and strategic issues

hostilities, has seriously disrupted global energy supplies.

At the same time, US President Donald Trump has also upended the world order and economic systems. His protectionist trade policies and the unleashing of punitive tariffs on countries, many of which have been important economic partners, have heightened global economic strain.

President Trump's perception of BRICS as an anti-Western coalition has brought threats of 100 per cent tariffs should the bloc attempt to replace the US dollar with a BRICS currency. President Trump's fears may be unfounded, though, as the issue of de-dollarisation has left BRICS divided. India maintains that it is not in favour of a shared currency. Russia, on the other hand, wants de-dollarisation, while China would like broader use of the renminbi.

With the theme, 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability' and the motto 'Humanity First', India, as host, aims to steer discussions towards economic, social and institutional resilience “to navigate global uncertainties” and supply chain disruptions.

It also wants multilateral engagement among members to deepen through development finance, trade facilitation and reforms in global institutional governance.

The plethora of issues BRICS members want to work together on, while commendable, also makes cooperation a daunting task. Though bound by three “core pillars” — political and security, economy and finance, and cultural and people-to-people exchanges — it faces structural hurdles. Its consensus-driven model, paired with stark differences in political and economic systems and foreign policy priorities, makes decision-making slow.

Moreover, the rapid expansion of BRICS risks diluting internal cohesion. India, wary of China using expansion to extend its own

influence within the bloc, has advocated consolidating existing membership over unchecked growth. It also remains guarded about China's hegemonic moves, given that Beijing has been seeking to extend its sphere of influence in the region and beyond. BRICS presents both an opportunity and a challenge. It is an opportunity in that it offers a platform for member states to cooperate and amplify their voices on the global stage on issues of common concern. It is a challenge because of the wide array of issues it seeks to address and the divergence in the views of its members amid a turbulent world order. However, the fact that this bloc has managed to grow in size and address a diversity of issues indicates its relevance.

However, BRICS does need to deliver substantive outcomes and put its money where its mouth is. Indeed, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said in May this year about BRICS, “Our relevance will depend on outcomes, not just on intent.”

For instance, the New Development Bank, established in 2015 to mobilise resources for infrastructure projects and sustainable development, has modest capital at its disposal. It needs to mobilise more capital if it is to meet the demands of the new members as well as the Global South. BRICS has been seeking a better deal for the Global South, which is in sync with India's championing of the cause of the Global South.

Ultimately, BRICS' long-term credibility will not be measured by additional member intake or lofty summit declarations, but by its capacity to deliver tangible outcomes. To avoid becoming an oversized talk shop, the bloc will need to bridge deep internal divides — most notably over de-dollarisation and regional rivalries — while adequately capitalising institutions like the New Development Bank.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Fire That Requires you to Sit Down Patiently

In our current life, we feel that acquiring wisdom is instant and much easier through social media by watching a reel or a video or reading a message that comes on WhatsApp without the need for any discipline in life. The word "Upanishad" itself tells a different story.

The term Upanishad is often translated as "sitting down near," referring to a student sitting close to a teacher, ready to receive knowledge with humility and full attention. But scholars also read a deeper layer within it, "upa-ni-shad," meaning to sit close to the fire, tending it patiently, since fire only reveals its power to those willing to feed it consistently, not those who approach it once and expect illumination.

Wisdom in the Vedic tradition was never treated as information to be consumed quickly. It required years of proximity to a teacher, sustained attention, and patient effort, much like a fire that must be tended, not just lit and left. Even the smallest spark, left unattended, dies out long before it can offer any real warmth or light. We chase quick fixes for slow problems, wanting patience, wisdom, or peace of mind, delivered as instantly as everything else in our lives. Today, choose one meaningful pursuit- work, learning or growth, anything that you do. Stay close to it, understand and commit yourself 100% to it with patience without expecting immediate results.

—DAIV

The questions we should never stop asking



SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

All languages are beautiful. There are words in each that draw us towards the beauty hidden within them. For me, some of the most fascinating words are also among the simplest: Why? What? Who? Where? When? How?

They are probably among the words every child discovers intuitively while beginning to explore the world around them. Why is the sky blue? Where does the sun go at night? How does an aeroplane remain in the air? Who decided that this should be called a table? The questions may appear absurd to an adult. To the child, they are perfectly reasonable. The universe is new and deserves an explanation.

Then, somewhere along the way, something changes. A parent, tired after a long day, responds impatiently to the tenth question. “Don’t ask so many questions.”

Nothing may change immediately. But repeat it often enough and the child begins to understand that curiosity can occasionally be inconvenient.

School can reinforce the lesson. There are portions to complete, examinations to prepare for and correct answers to remember. A persistent child may continue asking questions, but gradually many learn that knowing the expected answer is often more rewarding than asking an unexpected question. Those who carry the habit into college encounter another set of boundaries. And when they enter the workplace, many discover that it can sometimes be easier to nod politely at the profound wisdom being dispensed by seniors than to ask a simple, “Why?”

Perhaps that is where organisations should worry. Every organisation says it wants innovation. Leaders speak about disruption, creativity and thinking differently. Yet all three require something much more elementary: an environment in which somebody can ask why something is being done in a particular way without being considered difficult. The person asking the question may be wrong. The existing practice may have perfectly sound reasons behind it. But explaining those reasons strengthens understanding. Occasionally, however, there may be no convincing answer beyond, “This is how we have always done it.” And that is precisely when a question becomes valuable.

Human progress has depended upon people who looked at what everyone else accepted and wondered

why. Every discovery did not necessarily begin with a brilliant answer. Many began with an inconvenient question. And some changed the world simply by asking.

It is easy, of course, to expect children, students and younger colleagues to remain curious. Growing older has made me realise that the same expectation must apply to me. There is no embarrassment in asking my wife or my daughters a question to which I do not know the answer. Someone younger recently reminded me that I may not have all the answers. One of the privileges of growing older should be the freedom to say, “I don’t know. Let me find out.”

That is why I feel happy when a child asks me: Why? What? Who? Where? When? How?

I may not always know the answer. Sometimes there may not even be one. But providing an answer may be less important than ensuring that I do not make the child regret having asked the question.

And occasionally, instead of answering, I may need to ask the question with the child. Growing older may have given me answers to some questions I once asked, but it has also shown me how many more remain. Perhaps wisdom lies not merely in accumulating answers, but in retaining the curiosity — and the humility — to keep looking for them.

The writer is a founder of Kala - Crazy About Literature And Arts, and is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Dog menace: A growing challenge

It is imperative to prevent and restrict the dog menace in housing societies in and around Maharashtra, as people continue to suffer from dog bites and the risk of rabies. In response to a fresh Supreme Court directive, the Maharashtra Government has directed all civic bodies to remove stray dogs from public places such as schools, hospitals, bus depots, railway stations and sports complexes.

A new Government Resolution (GR) issued on Monday mandates immediate action by municipal corporations, councils and nagar panchayats. The GR directs local authorities to capture, sterilise and vaccinate stray dogs and relocate them to shelters. They cannot simply be returned to the same public areas.

Civic bodies must also establish clearly defined feeding zones for community dogs. Those who feed animals outside these designated areas will face action.

To help citizens report stray dog-related issues, the Government has made it mandatory for every local body to operate a helpline. Complaints will be monitored by a State coordinator based at the district headquarters to ensure proper implementation of the rules.

C K SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

ISRO and private space sector

India's decision to open its space sector to greater private participation in 2020 has led to the entry of several private companies and start-ups. This has raised concerns about the future role of ISRO and its employees. On September 4, 2026, nine ISRO employee associations sought clarification from ISRO Chairman V Narayanan on the possible transfer of launch-vehicle production, satellite manufacturing and operational responsibilities to private companies.

However, it would be inaccurate to conclude that ISRO is being privatised. On September 6, 2026, ISRO stated that it would neither be privatised nor have its importance diminished. It will continue to lead advanced research, strategic missions, space science and critical technologies.

India should establish clear roles for ISRO and private industry. ISRO should focus on advanced research, strategic missions and frontier technologies, while private companies can contribute to commercial satellites, launch services, manufacturing and mature technologies. Private participation should complement, not compete with, ISRO. A stronger partnership between the public and private sectors can promote technological self-reliance, national security and the sustainable growth of India's space capabilities.

DATTAPRASAD SHIRODKAR | MUMBAI

No place for gender discrimination

The recent closure of the Eiffel Tower following a staff walkout is not a mere “cultural misunderstanding”, but a shocking display of gender discrimination that demands condemnation. The demands reportedly made by the BAPS delegation, which led to female employees being instructed to stay out of sight, are a direct assault on the dignity of women in their workplace. It is unacceptable that a public landmark symbolising liberty and equality was compromised to accommodate patriarchal rules. The Eiffel Tower staff union deserves praise for drawing a hard line and refusing to let female colleagues be treated as second-class citizens to appease a wealthy and influential religious group.

Religious and cultural freedoms are not absolute; they end when they infringe upon the rights, safety and equality of others. This incident should serve as an urgent wake-up call for public institutions worldwide.

Moving forward, public spaces must adopt a strict zero-tolerance policy against any organisation that demands the segregation or erasure of women. Secular laws protecting equality must unequivocally take precedence over discriminatory demands made by any religious body.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

PICTALK



A baby orangutan, who was recently rescued with four others from Balasore district, plays with soft toys in a quarantine cell at the Nandankanan PHOTO: PTI



Rang-e-Cinema: The new celluloid brand in cinema

The first international film festival in Srinagar has done more than bring films and filmmakers to Kashmir. Rang-e-Cinema has opened a new conversation on the Valley's cinematic identity, positioning filmmaking, tourism, technology and the creative economy as interconnected engines of cultural and economic renewal



CHAITANYA K PRASAD

The curation of a new film festival always creates a positive buzz as it is instantaneous, looks vibrant, ideates new insights and institutionalises new curative thoughts. The recently concluded Rang-e-Kashmir is one example of innovation, excellence and scaling new frontiers in the celluloid space.

Film festivals today function as living ecosystems: nurturing voices, encouraging risk-taking and building transnational communities. Their role in shaping public perception, fostering policy discourse and enabling commercial success is more relevant than ever. The new festival circuit is breaking boundaries with purpose. It is showcasing new cinematic languages, driven by talent, diversity and digital disruption. The unified objective is clear: visualise the future of cinema through the lens of commercial viability, cutting-edge technology and artistic innovation. And festivals, in balancing these objectives, are becoming incubators of excellence, where ideas are born, refined and launched into the world.

Today, film festivals have evolved into sophisticated arenas that redefine cinematic expression. They are reshaping the celluloid experience through experiential storytelling, sustainable creative roadmaps and tech-enabled narratives that resonate across boundaries. Their evolution reflects a collective aspiration to reimagine the medium, not just in how films are made, but in how they are shared, discussed and remembered.

It is in this context that the first international film festival held in Srinagar under the theme "Rang-e-Cinema" becomes extremely important. By organising this festival, a message has gone across the cinematic ecosystem of a fresh initiative, design and insight into creating a niche presence in the film festival ecosystem.

The four-day festival certainly brings about a paradigm shift in the character, design and interconnectivity of hosting a film festival. "Rang-e-Cinema" boldly attempts to widen the ambit of a traditional film festival. It has ushered in a new brand idea for Kashmir as a filming destination, converged a new set of stakeholders and created a unique dhun of creativity, collaboration and participation for cinephiles and verticals under the ambit of a creator's economy.

The festival has truly regained the lost pristine glory of "Kashmir" within the celluloid landscape. As a platform, the festival has uniquely woven the idea of "Create, Shoot & Connect Cinema within Kashmir". With more than 135 films screened and with 40 countries participating, the festival has reframed and reoriented Kashmir's outreach to filmmaking.

There is no denying the fact that, in the late 1960s, filmmakers flocked to the state to capture its locales, legacy and the romantic spirit that combined effectively with the storytelling moods of those times. The state was uniquely called "India's Switzerland", a brand that surely survived the test of time. Each film demonstrated the emotions and romantic spectacle associated with music, lyrics and the mesmerising songs which still haunt us today.

"Rang-e-Cinema" has reconfigured a lost identity, a search for regaining the glory of the past. It has truly brought centre stage a new cinematic brand and identity for filmmaking within the state. It has acted as a catalyst for prospective filmmakers in their search for new possibilities, storyboards, narration and a new, bold cinematic vision. As a platform, the festival has created the buzz to position and place a filmmaking-friendly ecosystem and experience. A convergence point to kick-start a new chapter of initiating the path of the economy within the precincts of J&K.

If J&K is to build a serious cinematic identity, the festival must resist becoming a one-off showcase. The first step towards institutionalisation lies in temporal discipline. The festival must anchor itself firmly to a fixed calendar window, a defined geography and a stable identity. A fixed date positioning works strategically; it avoids overlap with global heavyweights while aligning with India's academic and cultural



"RANG-E-CINEMA" BOLDLY ATTEMPTS TO WIDEN THE AMBIT OF A TRADITIONAL FILM FESTIVAL. IT HAS USHERED A NEW BRAND IDEA TO KASHMIR AS A FILMING DESTINATION, CONVERGED A NEW SET OF STAKEHOLDERS AND CREATED A UNIQUE DHUN OF CREATIVITY, COLLABORATION AND PARTICIPATION FOR CINEPHILES, AND VERTICALS UNDER THE AMBIT OF A CREATOR'S ECONOMY

The writer is former Civil Servant, writes on Cinema and Strategic Communication. Inputs provided by Zoya Ahmad and Vaishnavie Srinivasan

cycles, but this must now be codified and protected. A festival that shifts in time and space each year risks losing not just recall, but relevance.

Once that foundation is in place, the next big shift has to be in how the festival programmes itself. Right now, it feels like a wide, fairly inclusive mix, and that's understandable for a first edition. But going forward, it has to feel more intentional. Less like a collection, more like a point of view. The difference between a good festival and a great one is not how many films it shows, but how clearly it knows what it wants to say through them.

That means building sections that feel thought-through. Bringing in more director-led storytelling, where the craft and perspective matter as much as the narrative itself. Giving real, central space to women-directed and women-centric cinema, not as a token category, but as a core part of the programming. And also leaning into films that engage with real, lived issues — social, political and environmental. Because the festivals that stay with you are the ones that reflect the moment you're living in.

At the same time, J&K has the opportunity to do something most festivals in India haven't fully managed yet: to become a space where cinema is not just screened, but developed. There is so much raw talent in J&K — students, theatre actors, independent creators and people experimenting with storytelling in ways that don't always find platforms. The festival can step into that gap. Script labs, pitching forums, casting platforms and youth sections — these aren't add-ons; they're what can make the festival feel alive beyond the screenings.

The overall objective of "Rang-e-Cinema" should be to establish filming protocols that institutionalise cinema, tourism, creative collaboration, exchange and a sustainable creative economy. Policymakers need to take the baton forward to weave together locational incentives, financial props, single-window clearances and the promotion of filming infrastructure through the lens of tourism and destination marketing, an idea that has excited in the past. The festival could act as a beginning and starting point, as a catalyst, window, gateway and platform for a sustained creator's economy.

"Rang-e-Cinema" should realistically assess the deliverables after the festival concludes, as well as the creative buzz that emerged after the event comes to a close. Its verticals must interconnect the heritage, legacy and contemporary cinematic language with experiences and ideas incubated within the festival duration. More importantly, the message should be: Cinema in India is seamless, interconnected and networked to a new language of storytelling.

The 3Cs mantra that defines any film festival ecosystem — Creativity, Culture and Commerce — has become the cornerstone of any film festival architecture, including Rang-e-Cinema. Today, film festivals have become transformative platforms unlocking new opportunities for content creation, cross-cultural collaboration, global networking, strategic partnerships and narrative innovation. In short, they are the modern-day catalysts where storytelling meets strategy. The perfect jugalbandi of ideas, content and outreach.



DEVESH CHATURVEDI

recruitment processes were cancelled, leading to huge delays in filling vacancies, consequent youth unrest and multiple litigations. The credibility of the process had nosedived. The State adopted the Government of India's policy relating to the abolition of interviews in Group C and Group B non-gazetted recruitment. An overarching amendment to the rules covering all such recruitment was carried out in August 2017. Since then, there has been systematic and concerted action to reform the recruitment procedure. For recruitment to Group C posts, the process has been made at least two-tiered. A single common preliminary examination for all categories of Group C posts, termed the Pre-Eligibility Test (PET), is conducted by the UPSSSC, which gives a score to each candidate. Initially, it was valid for one year, but it has now been extended to three years. The UPSSSC is successfully conducting the PET. Since 2021, the number of applicants in each examination has ranged between 18 and 27 lakh. Based on the PET score and merit, Tier 2 examinations are conducted for shortlisted candidates.

Advertisements for various Tier 2 or main examinations are issued by clubbing similar vacancies, and the number of candidates shortlisted is usually 15 times the total number of advertised posts. Due to the relatively lower number of candidates in Tier 2, these examinations can be conducted swiftly and in a very close and secure environment, without any possibility of unfair practices. The final merit list is prepared based on the results of the Tier 2 examination. While the abolition of interviews removed subjectivity, the two-tier examination reduced the burden on candidates. The results could be declared within a compressed time schedule. Having put this pattern in place, other reforms, along with technology-based interventions, have been introduced to minimise the possibility of the process being impacted by paper leaks. These steps include:

(i) A very careful selection of examination centres is undertaken. A thorough scrutiny is carried out by a committee chaired by District Magistrates, and preference is given to Government-owned institutes, followed by Government-aided schools.

(ii) Candidates are allotted examination centres on a random basis and are not allotted centres situated in their divisions or districts of domicile, to prevent any possibility of candidates exerting undue local influence. Only physically challenged candidates are exempted from this criterion.

(iii) Multiple question paper series are printed and sent to district treasuries. One set is randomly chosen a few hours before the commencement of the examination to reduce the chances of leakage. In case of reports of any leakage before the start of the examination, the leaked set can be abandoned and the examination process completed without any obstacle.

(iv) Each of these paper series has multiple sets, with the sequence of questions and options jumbled. The series is not identifiable but is coded based on the unique serial number of the question paper.

(v) The Optical Mark Recognition (OMR) sheets used by candidates to answer the questions are prepared in three copies. One is taken away by the candidates, the second is securely kept in the treasury to be used for verification, if required, and the third is sent for evaluation.

(vi) Sector Magistrates and one Static Sector Magistrate are deputed at each centre for proper supervision and control.

(vii) The invigilators at the examination centres are randomly allotted examination rooms by the Static Sector Magistrate minutes before the commencement of the examination, to prevent any prior planning for unfair practices. Technology-based solutions, such as CCTV cameras in each examination room and iris recognition devices to capture and cross-verify the biometric data of candidates appearing in the main examination with their previously captured data in the PET, have been implemented to prevent impersonation. Artificial Intelligence tools are also being deployed to match the faces of candidates appearing in the examination with the photographs on their admit cards, to identify suspicious cases and raise alerts for rigorous verification.

The UPSSSC, responsible for recruiting candidates for gazetted posts, has undertaken additional reforms to make the process more objective and transparent. The optional paper was removed from the mains examination, ensuring a level playing field and eliminating the need for moderation across multiple subjects. The interview process was also made more accountable by concealing candidates' names, caste and educational institutions from interview board members, with boards and candidates assigned randomly. Experts are involved in grading candidates, while answer sheets can be displayed on demand after results are declared.

Following the Union Government's policy, the State has also removed the requirement for prior character verification before issuing appointment letters. Provisional appointment letters are now issued based on self-declaration, subject to subsequent verification. This has reduced the time gap between the declaration of results and appointment. The districts are allotted to candidates according to the vacancies available, their ranks and the choices made by them during the counselling. Since the issuance of an appointment letter with the place of posting is the first interaction of new recruits with the system, online counselling enables a corruption- and nepotism-free process, spreading a positive vibe among the young entrants. Once the counselling is over, a public event is organised for the distribution of appointment letters, which is graced by the Chief Minister and other dignitaries. At several events, the message of the Hon'ble Prime Minister to the new recruits is also broadcast. As a result of these reforms, transparency in the recruitment process has been restored to a large extent. The credibility of the Government and recruiting agencies has been enhanced, with the process becoming merit-based, inclusive and corruption-free. The recruitment process is being completed within a shortened time frame, with robust procedures.



BRICS at 20: United by difference



ANURADHA PS

Perhaps the most salient feature of BRICS is its lack of uniformity, twenty years after the formation of the group. It has a diverse membership with varying political systems, economic bases, strategic interests and relationships

with the great powers. In spite of trade and cooperation in multilateral forums, India and China are still viewed as strategic competitors. In its conflict with the West, Russia has found itself in a much different geopolitical situation than India, Brazil or some of the newer members. The Gulf economies provide a different energy, financial and investment paradigm to the "original" BRICS. Yet, BRICS has flourished and expanded. This paradox is more significant than the more common BRICS-G7 juxtaposition. At 20, the only question is whether BRICS has become big enough to challenge another group. It is whether a group of increasingly different countries can turn their numbers into collective power.

BRICS started as an economic initiative. The term was coined in 2001 and referred to the four emerging economies of Brazil, Russia, India and China, whose increasing influence would potentially alter the global economy. This was followed by the political grouping in 2006, and South Africa entered the fold in 2011. It was then changed in nature by its

further development. BRICS is no longer an association of fast-growing economies. It now numbers 11 members and is becoming a forum for countries with different interests to have a greater voice in global governance, as well as seeking practical economic cooperation. The 18th BRICS Summit will be held in New Delhi on 12-13 September 2026 on issues related to trade, finance, technology, energy, agriculture, climate and institutional reform. With this expansion, BRICS becomes more demographically and economically powerful. It also poses a more difficult question, however, which is whether a more representative grouping is a more effective one. Not necessarily. The more varied the interests and the more members that join, the more difficult the balancing act. Expansion may generate legitimacy and, at the same time, exacerbate the consensus price. This tension shouldn't be considered a fluke. It could be one of the most distinguishing aspects of BRICS in its 30th year.

The traditional method of assessing international groupings is based upon the level of political agreement they can reach. A different yardstick is needed for BRICS. Its members do not need a common foreign policy or to become a political coalition. They need the ability to discover common points of interest and create institutions for the surrounding. This is a case of "co-operation, not convergence". India, for example, is a member of the Quad, the G20 and BRICS. Increasingly, strategic autonomy is about operating in more than one institution rather than being on one side or the other. BRICS fits into this more fluid international environment. This logic has proven effective to



some degree. In the last two decades, trade among BRICS countries has undergone phenomenal growth. But the key is how much more trade would happen if transaction costs were reduced. Trade facilitation, customs cooperation, common standards, logistics, investment channels and reliable payment mechanisms should therefore be a focus for BRICS.

The New Development Bank is likely BRICS's most tangible institutional accomplishment. Created in 2015, it has sanctioned investments in 139 projects totalling \$42.9 billion, including clean energy, transport, water, sanitation, social infrastructure and digital infrastructure.

However, BRICS can't ignore its internal tensions. With the expanding grouping, a lack of consensus has become more apparent. A May 2026 meeting of BRICS foreign ministers ended in a statement by the chair rather than a common declaration. This need not mean failure; it could instead indicate what BRICS can realistically be. Collective

action will become more difficult if all members are expected to agree on major geopolitical issues. If consensus is required only in some areas, with differentiated cooperation in others, BRICS may become more effective. This would mean moving from "What does BRICS collectively believe?" to "What can BRICS collectively do?"

The distinction is significant in the context of the India-China relationship. The two nations reflect both the potential and constraints of BRICS. They are important trading partners and members of the same multilateral institutions, but differences in strategy, economic-security concerns and regional ambitions remain unresolved. BRICS cannot solve the India-China relationship, but it can provide a space where cooperation in unrelated fields is not derailed by competition.

BRICS must also resist defining itself through opposition to the West. Its more enduring role lies in reform rather than rejection. India's BRICS priorities for 2026 focus on resilience, innovation, cooperation and sustainability, with emphasis on trade, technology, development and climate. The opportunity is to build BRICS less as a "geopolitical signal" and more as an institutional "delivery".

The third decade should therefore be judged by practical outcomes: easier trade, greater access to development finance, secure payment systems and cooperation on digital infrastructure, AI, climate adaptation, energy transition and health technologies. These are not 'show' questions. They're important ones. They also provide a means to embrace the diversity of the grouping. Interests need not be identical for payments cooperation to be possible. They do not have to have the same geo-political agenda to fund renewables. They do not have to agree on all matters of international conflict to work together on agricultural technology or disaster resistance. This implies a new institutional format for BRICS — discussion and cooperation based on specific issues within a wide political space. Some members might run faster in some parts than others. This does not necessarily have to be a flaw. In an increasingly diverse mix, it might be the only realistic method that will keep the group moving. BRICS at 20 should give rise to a paradox for BRICS as it begins its third decade. It is its best achievement that it has weathered differences that could have split a stiffer alliance. The biggest danger it has is that growth might lead to the loss of flexibility and become vague. The answer is not to impose the conventional definition of a geopolitical bloc on BRICS. Nor is it to boast of its size without inquiring about the product of its size.

In India, the more beneficial goal is to strengthen processes that allow disagreement while fostering effective cooperation. This requires focusing on tangible achievements, strong institutions and measurable economic and development results rather than grand statements or competition for power.

BRICS, at the age of 20, does not have to show that it speaks as one. It must show how countries with different interests can achieve outcomes together that they couldn't achieve alone. The next obstacle it must overcome is the challenge of being consequential.

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Order Order

SC urges front-of-pack warning labels on packaged food

The Supreme Court on Thursday said it is concerned about the health of people, especially growing children, and wants all concerned with food safety to consider in "national interest" the issue of front-of-pack warning labels for packaged products containing high salt, sugar and fat products. A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said it will pass a detailed order calling for some information from the stakeholders on the "serious matter".

"We are only concerned about the health of people, especially growing children. We want all the concerned to consider the cause in national interest," the bench said, while indicating that the order will be uploaded in a day or two. The top court said it has also done some homework on the issue and asked the parties to study the order to be uploaded and posted the matter for hearing on September 28.

During the brief hearing on the plea filed by a public charitable trust '3S and Our Health Society, the bench told the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) that the contents on packaged food products are always there on the rear side of the packet but has the authority laid down any guidelines whether if the content exceeds this limit, then it's high in sugar or salt or fat?

(PTI)

SC notice to Govt, police over Metro station closures

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought response from the Centre, Delhi Police and others on a plea against the closure of 17 metro stations in the city during the Cockroach Janta protests.

The closure of 17 metro stations and security restrictions around the protest site at Jantar Mantar in July threw traffic out of gear across central Delhi, leaving commuters stranded for hours at several spots and forcing many to take longer and costlier routes. A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notice to the Union of India, Delhi Police, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation and others on a plea filed by advocate Sparsh Kant Nayak. During the hearing, the counsel appearing for the petitioner submitted that the petition concerns the constitutional rights of the public at large and the constitutional standards governing the shutting down of a public utility.

(PTI)



Calcutta HC grants meeting permission to TMC supremo

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday granted conditional approval to the Mamata Banerjee faction of the Trinamool Congress to hold a rally at Serampore in Hooghly district. The meeting will be held on Friday. Serampore is about 35 km north west of Kolkata.

As the Bengal Police earlier refused to grant permission to hold the rally the Mamata faction of the party moved the Court of Justice Saugato Bhattacharya who however denied the party to organise a procession after the police administration submitted that it could lead to a massive traffic jam in the busy Grand Trunk Road. The Court only allowed the party to hold a meeting and also restricted its strength to 2000 participants.

Besides, the Court also asked the petitioners not to use any provocative slogan besides asking the police to deploy adequate forces to avoid any untoward incident.

(PNS)

Will consider granting permanent commission to women officers: Indian Coast Guard to SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Coast Guard on Thursday told the Supreme Court that it will consider Short Service Appointee (SSA) officer Priyanka Tyagi and other similarly placed women for grant of permanent commission after receiving their vigilance clearance reports.

A permanent commission (PC) offers a lifelong career in the armed forces until retirement, in contrast to a Short Service Commission (SSC) that provides a fixed-tenure engagement of 10 to 14 years.

The top court, by separate verdicts, had earlier allowed grant of PC to women SSC officers in the Army, Air Force and Navy. On August 19, the top court had come down heavily on the Indian Coast Guard (ICG) for not granting permanent commission to a female officer, saying "we will not allow women officers



to be humiliated".

On Thursday, a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana was informed by Attorney General R Venkataramani, appearing for the ICG and the Centre, that the force will proceed to consider granting PC after ascertaining the eligibility of Tyagi and other desirous women officers.

The top law officer said that before the selection committee proceeds with the issue, the ICG has to wait for the vigilance reports of

Too many laws, too little justice

To fight the monumental battle of rampant corruption in India, it is high time to address the issue as a priority; surely, India can follow the Chinese model to confront corruption that made China a global powerhouse. India's vision of Viksit Bharat 20247 can be attained only when the country adopts a zero-tolerance policy against systematic corruption



India does not lack laws. It suffers from a shortage of consequences. Parliament has enacted hundreds of laws to regulate business, collect taxes, punish wrongdoing and protect citizens. Yet, corruption continues to flourish because enforcement remains uncertain, investigations drag on for years and powerful individuals can often use influence, money and procedure to delay accountability. The uncomfortable question is whether Governments and bureaucracies sometimes allow unnecessarily complicated systems to survive because such systems keep the political and administrative machinery relevant. The larger the bureaucracy, the greater the discretionary power; the greater the discretion, the greater the opportunity for rent-seeking. When an ordinary citizen cannot obtain a certificate, licence, permission, utility connection or Government service without approaching an intermediary, corruption ceases to be an exception and becomes part of the operating system.

The recent case study of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code illustrates this danger. The IBC was created with a legitimate and necessary objective to resolve stressed companies quickly and recover maximum value for creditors. A modern economy needs an effective insolvency mechanism, and genuine business failure should never be treated as a crime. An entrepreneur who builds a company, creates employment and subsequently fails because of recession, market disruption, competition, technological change or circumstances beyond his control must have an opportunity for rehabilitation. But the same protection cannot be extended to

someone who deliberately diverts bank funds, creates shell companies, falsifies accounts, siphons assets abroad or manipulates lenders. Insolvency may settle a financial liability; it cannot wash away criminal liability. When creditors accept enormous haircuts on public-sector bank loans, the public has a right to ask who ultimately bears the loss: the bank, the depositor, the shareholder or the taxpayer. The fundamental principle must therefore be clear: failure should not frighten entrepreneurship, but fraud must frighten every person contemplating it.

The same standard must apply to public servants and institutions. Whether the person is a politician, bureaucrat, judge, police officer, regulator, municipal employee, banker or any other individual drawing salary, pension, wages or retainerhip from the public exchequer, corruption involving public money must carry consequences severe enough to change the calculation between risk and reward. India should seriously debate a stringent statutory framework under which a public servant convicted of serious corruption after a fair judicial process faces at least 20 years' long-term imprisonment to the death penalty, confiscation and recovery of illicitly acquired assets, and permanent disqualification from public office wherever legally and constitutionally permissible. The purpose should not be revenge. It should be deterrence. A system in which a person can steal or facilitate the theft of public money and still retain wealth, influence and social standing after years of litigation is not a deterrent system; it is an invitation.

Today, corruption can sometimes appear to be a low-risk, high-reward activity. An investigation can take years, a trial can take decades and appeals can continue indefinitely. Witnesses disappear, records become unavailable, evidence weakens and public attention moves elsewhere. Meanwhile, the accused may continue to enjoy the proceeds of wrongdoing. This is



where the Indian system needs a fundamental correction. The real deterrent is not the maximum punishment written in a statute; it is the certainty that punishment will actually follow misconduct.

The justice system itself must become an integral part of this reform. Deliberately forged documents, fabricated evidence, knowingly false affidavits and false testimony under oath should attract serious consequences, including 20 years' rigorous imprisonment to the death penalty after due process. Honest mistakes, incomplete information and unsuccessful legal arguments must never be criminalised. But deliberate deception of courts and government authorities must become a high-risk activity. Courts cannot deliver speedy justice when litigants can manufacture documents, conceal material facts, file frivolous proceedings and prolong disputes for decades without meaningful consequences. Those who deliberately abuse the judicial process must understand that the court is not merely a forum in which endless arguments can be made; it is an institution whose authority cannot be manipulated with impunity.

This is where the India-China comparison becomes relevant, not as a recommendation that India

imitate China's political system, but as a warning about the consequences of weak enforcement. China began rebuilding its supervisory machinery during the reform era, including the establishment of its Ministry of Supervision in 1987. After 2012, under Xi Jinping, the Chinese Communist Party's Central Commission for Discipline Inspection and later the National Supervisory Commission launched an exceptionally aggressive anti-corruption campaign. Senior officials, bankers, regulators, state-owned enterprise executives and local functionaries were investigated and punished. The campaign also pursued illicit assets and officials who had fled overseas. Whatever one's political assessment of the Chinese system, one lesson is difficult to ignore: laws become meaningful when people believe that position, wealth and connections cannot automatically protect them from consequences.

India has the advantage that China does not have a constitutional democracy based on fundamental rights, judicial review, political pluralism and institutional checks and balances. India does not need political fear. It needs the fear of lawful consequences. The politician must know that public office cannot provide immunity. The bureaucrat

must know that taking a bribe can end a career and destroy illegally acquired wealth. The banker must know that fraudulent lending can lead to imprisonment. The businessman must know that deliberate diversion of public money cannot disappear behind an insolvency haircut. The litigant must know that fabricated evidence can destroy his case. The taxpayer must know exactly what he owes, and equally importantly, know that the government is accountable for every rupee it collects.

Ultimately, corruption survives on four pillars: uncertain punishment, endless litigation, excessive discretion and diluted accountability. Remove these four pillars and the incentive structure changes fundamentally. The real test of governance is therefore brutally simple: can an ordinary Indian live, work, conduct business, obtain government services and access justice without bribing an official, hiring a tout, negotiating with an intermediary or spending years fighting the system? If the answer remains no, India does not need another slogan, another committee or another law or anti-corruption institution. It needs a system in which breaking the law becomes genuinely dangerous and obeying the law becomes genuinely easier.

The lesson from China should therefore not be authoritarianism. It should be accountability. India does not need a government that frightens its citizens; it needs institutions that make corrupt officials, fraudulent businessmen, dishonest bankers and habitual abusers of the legal system afraid of the consequences of their own actions. The ultimate measure of a strong state is not how many laws it can enact, but how certain it can make the consequences of breaking them. India has enough laws. What it urgently needs is institutional reforms and the courage to enforce them.

The author is a public policy expert and columnist

CJP protest: SC seeks report on minor girl's allegation, says nobody can browbeat victim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday took serious view of allegations of harassment of a minor girl who participated in the July Cockroach Janta Party protests and said the nobody can be permitted to browbeat a victim or her family for pursuing criminal proceedings.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta to ensure action on the girl's FIR and sought report from Delhi and Uttar Pradesh governments on the issue.

"Such matters cannot be taken lightly. Nobody should be protected if violence against a child is involved... if persons accused of such acts were roaming free and attempting to browbeat the



child or her family so that they do not pursue criminal proceedings, it would be a serious matter.

"There cannot be any second opinion about it. Such matters cannot be taken lightly. Nobody should be protected. If violence against a child is involved and persons are roaming free and trying to browbeat the child or her family so that they do not pursue the criminal proceedings, that may be a serious matter," the bench observed.

The counsel appearing for the 14-year old girl told the

court that she was harassed and her house was vandalised after she registered the FIR against a person who claimed in a video that he had attacked her father during the CJP's protest.

Without referring to any names, the lawyer said instead of prosecuting those who were accompanying the accused and were allegedly caught on camera, an FIR has been registered against the child.

This is also contrary to the Supreme Court's earlier order, the lawyer said, adding that

video can be placed on record showing that the girl's residence had been subjected to stone pelting. "The high-powered committee will take time, but if something happens to the child in the meantime, that cannot subsequently be reversed or repaired through the committee," the counsel submitted.

Responding to the submission, the CJI said, "If there are anti-social elements who indulged in violence against child, and they are roaming free, and are trying to browbeat the child, that may be a serious thing."

Earlier, Delhi Police on September 5 had added provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and criminal intimidation to the FIR against Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj over the alleged assault on the minor activist's father during the CJP-led protests.

SC refuses to transfer Delhi building collapse case from HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday said it is not transferring to itself the Satya Niketan building collapse case being heard by the Delhi High Court as "things have started moving".

A bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahdevan said it does not want to disturb the existing situation and the high court will continue to monitor the compliance of its directions in a short interval. The five-storey building housing a boys' paying guest (PG) accommodation in Satya Niketan, near Delhi University's South Campus, collapsed around 1.30 pm on Sunday, leaving seven dead and 12 injured.

Senior advocate Ajit Sinha, who has been appointed amicus curiae in the matter, submitted that he has come to know through his sources and media reports that civic



authorities have started acting against unauthorised constructions and PG accommodations and anything beyond four storeys is being demolished.

Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Delhi government and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), also urged the bench not to transfer the case from the high court as civic authorities were acting in a more focused manner.

The bench accepted the suggestion of the amicus curiae and the SG, and said it is not transferring the case and that its earlier directions against unauthorised construction shall be complied with.

SC rejects bail plea of Abhishek Banerjee's PA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday rejected the anticipatory bail plea of TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee's personal assistant Sumit Roy in the Salboni land scam case where West Bengal government land was allegedly sold and the sale proceeds were deposited in the party's account. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana also vacated its earlier order of August 6 by which it had stayed Roy's arrest.

Consequently, Roy can now be arrested for custodial interrogation in the case. The bench heard the submissions of senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for Roy, and Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state government, before declining relief to the accused.

During the hearing, Sankaranarayanan said Roy has not been named as an accused in the FIR and strong-



ly opposed the prosecution's plea for his custodial interrogation. The bench examined a report submitted by the state police regarding the interrogation of Roy. The solicitor general had furnished a note concerning the interrogation, which was also shared with the petitioner's counsel.

He said Roy had been evasive during questioning and referred to substantial cash deposits made contemporaneously with the alleged transactions.

"At first blush", the material placed before the bench

could appear serious, Sankaranarayanan said, but questioned the manner and sequence in which Roy had been interrogated. He said Roy had been questioned for approximately 88 hours but had not been confronted with material which directly established his involvement in the alleged land transactions.

"There is nothing in these 88 hours of questioning which has distilled down to these half a dozen pages of questions," the senior lawyer said. He said Roy had not been shown deposit slips, contemporaneous banking records

bearing his signature or handwriting, or other material identifying him as the person who allegedly made the deposits. Sankaranarayanan also submitted that Roy had not been confronted with any complainant or alleged victim claiming that money had been paid to him.

"The allegation apparently is that government land was being sold to private persons. Those purchasers would be the affected persons," he added. He further said Roy had not been confronted with any material establishing a link between alleged forged documents, payments received from victims and the cash deposits relied upon by the investigating agency.

A substantial part of the arguments centred on cash deposits allegedly made in the account of All India Trinamool Congress (AITC).

Sankaranarayanan said that Roy was being questioned about transactions in the political party's account even though the criminal case was not against the party.

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Bihar peak power demand touches 9.5 GW

Bihar's peak power demand has reached around 9.5 GW, and the government is continuing to gear up to meet future electricity needs, State Energy Minister Shailesh Kumar said on Thursday. The minister made the remarks while addressing Bengal Chamber of Commerce and Industry's Energy Conclave in the national capital. Earlier, the power availability in rural areas was a big challenge, he said, adding that continuous power supply is a key priority of his government. Kumar said the state has made progress in the power sector and today there are 23-24 hours of power supply in urban areas, while 22-23 hours in rural areas. "Bihar is giving power supply to 2.22 crore consumers and has successfully met the peak demand of 9,475 MW," he added.

(PTI)

India-SACU PTA to help boost investments: SA envoy

The proposed preferential trade agreement (PTA) between India and SACU group would help boost two-way commerce and investments between New Delhi and South Africa, South African High Commissioner to India Anil Sooklal said. Sooklal said the country's engagement with India has evolved into a broad-based partnership covering trade, investment, technology, skills and development cooperation. He said the proposed PTA has "tremendous scope" to significantly expand trade and investment between the two countries, creating new opportunities for businesses and helping both economies flourish. On August 12, India and SACU group signed terms of references (ToRs) for launching negotiations for a PTA. ToRs sets out broad parameters for trade pact talks. The five members of SACU (South African Customs Union) are Botswana, Eswatini (formerly Swaziland), Lesotho, Namibia and South Africa.

(PTI)

The Pioneer

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BUSINESS

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India, Russia fast-track investment treaty talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Russia are fast-tracking negotiations for a new bilateral investment treaty (BIT) with an aim to provide legal certainty to investors of both countries, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday. Addressing the India-Russia Business Dialogue here with Russian Minister of Industry and Trade Anton Alikhanov, Goyal also said that both the countries are committed to the early conclusion of talks for the India- and Russia-led EAEU free trade agreement. The five members of the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) are Armenia, Belarus,

Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Russia. The pact, he said, would open new markets for industries including MSMEs. "We (India-Russia) are fast-tracking a new bilateral investment treaty to give investors on both sides the legal certainty that projects and businesses look for when they are finalising investment decisions," he said. "We continue to strengthen local currency settlement mechanisms, because payment friction, more often than tariffs, is what slows trade down on the ground," he added. Goyal called for an accelerated India-Russia economic and industrial partnership, urging businesses from both

countries to work towards achieving the target of USD 100 billion in bilateral trade and USD 50 billion in two-way investment by 2030. At present, the bilateral trade stood at USD 60 billion.

Increasing bilateral trade from the current base of around USD 60 billion would require adding about USD 40 billion in the next four years and sustained double-digit growth year-on-year,

he said. He stressed that achieving this would require significant efforts not only from the governments but equally from businesses in both countries. Highlighting the opportunities for diversifying bilateral trade, Goyal said that Indian exports of meat and edible meat products had more than doubled from USD 36 million to USD 97 million, an increase of nearly 170 per cent. Fish and aquatic products grew from USD 123 million to USD 159 million, an increase of nearly 30 per cent, while exports of edible vegetables rose from USD 38 million to USD 54 million, an increase of 40 per cent. Similarly, shipments of

coffee, tea and spices increased by 13 per cent to USD 116 million, while products of the milling industry had nearly doubled. "These figures reflected growing demand in the Russian market for products from Indian farmers, food processors, micro, small and medium enterprises and MSME exporters," he added. However, he said that only a small portion of the potential had been tapped so far. Referring to the complementarity between the two economies, he said there were several products where Russia is a significant importer, and India is a significant exporter globally, but India is not yet a significant exporter to Russia.

Jefferies flags India's new industrial revolution across six high-growth sectors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Global investment bank Jefferies in a report published on September 9, 2026 has highlighted what it calls "India's New Industrial Revolution", driven by a large domestic market, rising private-sector participation and sustained policy support. The report specifically points to measures such as opening space to private players, tax holidays for data centres, incentive schemes for semiconductors, electronics and solar, localisation measures and government GPU purchases as key enablers of growth across these emerging sectors. In the context of Space, Jefferies says India is among a handful

of spacefaring nations with globally competitive capabilities. The space economy is targeted to grow ~5x to \$40-45 billion by 2030, with private firms such as Skyroot, Pixxel and Agnikul moving towards commercial execution. On the Semiconductors rev-

olution, India's push is moving from policy to execution, with around \$20 billion of investment, a chip fab under construction and several OSAT projects starting production. A further \$13 billion incentive plan is expected to deepen the ecosystem. In the context of Data

Centres the report mentions capacity has grown 5x in five years to ~2 GW and is expected to reach ~10 GW in the next five years, creating a \$45 billion investment opportunity across power, cooling, construction and networks. In the field of electronics it said India is moving from assembly towards higher domestic value addition and component manufacturing. It expects domestic value addition in mobile components to rise from below 20 per cent to around 50 per cent over the next 6 years. Highlighting the solar energy sector, Jefferies said India is now the world's second-largest solar PV manufacturer, with ~35 GW of cell capacity operational and another ~100 GW under con-

struction. Jefferies expects ~90 per cent of the value chain to be localised by 2030. In the aerospace sector it said India is emerging as a beneficiary of the global aerospace demand-supply imbalance, supported by cost-competitive manufacturing and engineering talent. Boeing and Airbus already source \$1.4-1.6 billion annually from India, while Indian firms are supplying global OEMs and Tier-1 companies. The report's broader point is that India's large domestic opportunity, rising private participation and government support are driving the expansion of new industries, with growing domestic capacity and global competitiveness, the international report added.

Rupee closes at 95.46 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee depreciated 38 paise to close at 95.46 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, as Brent crude breached the \$102 threshold, mounting concerns over the country's import cost trajectory. Forex traders said the cur-

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)	Change
3	94.51	+0.22
4	94.43	+0.08
7	94.56	-0.13
8	94.74	-0.18
9	95.08	-0.34
10	95.46	-0.38

*Provisional
September 2026
(Inverted scale) KBK Infographics

rency is currently facing opposing forces, with downside pressure driven by a resumption of foreign portfolio outflows, following positive flows in July and August and crude oil trading above \$102 per barrel. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.15 against the US dollar, then lost ground to close at 95.46 (provisional) against the American currency, registering a loss of 38 paise from its previous close. On Wednesday, the rupee slumped 34 paise to close at 95.08 against the American currency.

Markets rebound after three-day decline

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Snapping their three-session losing streak, benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty edged higher on Thursday amid lag-end stock-specific buying despite the cautious market undertone. However, elevated crude oil prices above the \$100-per-barrel mark, amid persistent geopolitical tensions, kept risk appetite subdued throughout day, traders said. The market remained range-bound for the most part of session as investors kept their exposure lower. The 30-share BSE Sensex advanced 138.36 points, or 0.19 per cent, to settle at 74,902.59 on last-minute buying. During the day, it hit

Index	Open	High	Low	Close	Change
NSE NIFTY	23,446.60	23,494.95	23,380.10	23,477.80	+46.30 (0.20%)
BSE SENSEX	74,742.54	74,910.96	74,598.47	74,902.59	+138.36 (0.19%)

KBK Infographics

a high of 74,910.96 and a low of 74,598.47. The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 46.30 points, or 0.20 per cent, to end at 23,477.80. "Indian equities ended marginally higher on Thursday, shrugging off weak

global cues and Brent crude hovering near USD 102 a barrel, as selective buying in financials and oil & gas stocks offset broader caution," Hariselman Radhakrishnan, Founder & CEO of HST Wealth, a Research Analyst firm, said.

PepsiCo opens its first food factory in Assam for ₹778 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nalbari (Assam)

Leading food and beverage maker PepsiCo India on Thursday opened its first food factory in Assam, set up with an investment of ₹778 crore in Nalbari district. Inaugurated by Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, the unit is spread across 44.2 acres and has created 700 direct and indirect employment opportunities. "The inauguration of PepsiCo India's food manufacturing facility in Nalbari is another important milestone in Assam's industrial growth story. This investment underscores the confidence that leading global companies

have in Assam's business-friendly policies, infrastructure development and skilled workforce," Sarma said. Beyond generating employment and economic activity, the project will strengthen the state's agricultural ecosystem and create new opportunities for farmers, women and local enterprises, he added.

Apparel retail growth to moderate to 13% in FY27: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

India's organised apparel retail sector is projected to grow 12-13 per cent this fiscal, moderating from the 15 per cent growth recorded in the previous year, as consumers increasingly spread discretionary spending across categories beyond clothing, a report said on Thursday. Revenue growth has been broadly steady so far in the high single digits between April and August 2026, but has largely been driven by the value-fashion segment, Crisil Ratings said in the report. The organised apparel retail sector's revenue growth is expected to

remain healthy this fiscal, growing 12-13 per cent, though slightly lower than the 15 per cent recorded last fiscal, amid a broader diversification of consumer discretionary spending, it added. However, the growth is

expected to be supported by strong demand for value fashion, expansion of organised retail beyond big cities and continued preference for branded apparel. Higher cotton prices and rising operating costs are

likely to squeeze margins, as intense competition may limit retailers' ability to pass on higher costs to consumers. Operating margins are expected to fall by about 100 basis points to 14 per cent this fiscal. However, credit profiles are likely to remain stable because retailers are pursuing calibrated expansion strategies in larger cities that do not strain balance sheets, and expansion in smaller cities requires a relatively lower capital outlay. The festive season, which has recently commenced, will be crucial to the sector's growth outlook because festive spending typically accounts for nearly 35 per cent of annual apparel sales.

"Value fashion has emerged as the key growth driver for organised retailers, growing more than twice as fast as the other segments over the past three fiscal years and increasing its share of revenue. "The shift reflects an increasing share of aspirational consumption by price-conscious consumers, wider choice at lower price points and increasing penetration into smaller cities. While value fashion will continue to support volume growth, the rising share of lower-priced apparel is expected to moderate organised apparel retail revenue growth to 12-13 per cent this fiscal," Crisil Ratings Senior Director Anuj Sethi said.

Indian boardrooms stuck at compliance-level women tally, action needed: Arundhati Bhattacharya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Affirmative action remains necessary as women's representation in corporate boardrooms continues to hover at minimum compliance levels, Salesforce South Asia President and CEO Arundhati Bhattacharya said on Thursday, while also cautioning that the rapid adoption of artificial intelligence risks deepening existing gender biases. Speaking at the Global Fintech Fest 2026, the former State Bank of India (SBI) chairperson noted that while regulatory mandates ensured the entry of

women into boardrooms initially through family members and subsequently via independent directors-most companies have failed to progress beyond appointing just one woman director. "It's not that I am very much in favour of things like affirmative action. But when you have tried everything and still not achieved it, then affirmative action is what is required. Just look at the boardrooms of India," she pointed out. Highlighting emerging technological disruptions, Bhattacharya flagged the risk of artificial intelligence models amplifying gender disparity due to systemic

gaps in data availability. "There is a risk that the gender bias will actually go up because AI tends to work on available material, train itself on available material, and the kind of material that is available on women doing various things is appreciably lower than that which is available on men. So obviously, the trends will automatically tend towards that, and you have to be very careful about whatever model you're using to ensure that the bias doesn't creep in," she said. She also pointed to a digital divide within households, which hinders women from accessing

modern digital tools and generative AI platforms. In lower-middle-class homes, the woman is typically the last to receive a mobile handset, often receiving older or hand-me-down devices rather than modern smartphones, she observed. "Whether they use ChatGPT or Gemini or Claude... if they're not actually using it, they don't know what it can do, and therefore the access gets limited, and that again pushes them back. There has to be a very clearly defined policy as to how you can bring women to participate equally in the way things are changing today," she noted.

Reflecting on corporate policies, Bhattacharya recalled introducing a two-year sabbatical for women to prevent mid-career dropouts driven by childcare or eldercare duties. However, she observed that technology and post-pandemic hybrid work arrangements have now made such career breaks largely avoidable by offering flexibility in working hours and locations. Addressing cultural expectations, Bhattacharya said that true parity requires a shift in how families bring up boys. Sons must witness fathers sharing domestic responsibilities, attending parent-

teacher meetings, adjusting professional schedules for their spouses' careers, and celebrating their wives' achievements without feeling diminished, she said. She also voiced discomfort with labels like "women leadership" and specialised corporate awards. "What is women leadership? It's leadership. But why do you have to call them out separately? Because they are so few in number... I would love for us to be so many that you don't need to count... in 10 years if we don't achieve it, then we will be doing ourselves and the future generations a disservice," she said.

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NOTICE INVITING TENDERS							
Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation Limited (MPRDC) Bhopal invites online tenders for the following works.							
S. No.	(Group) MPRDC Division	S. No.	Name of Work	PAC Value (in INR Crore)	Bid Security (EMD) (in INR Lacs)	Cost of Tender Document (i/c GST) (in Rs.)	Period of Completion (i/c Rainy Seasons)
1.	Group-A Bhopal	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Eastern Bhopal Bypass Road (Total Length - 63 Km.)	48.09	24.05	59,000/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Bareli - Pipariya road (SH - 62) from Km. Ch. 0+000 to 39+000 (Total Length - 39 Km.)				
		3.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Khamariya-Sultanpur Naktara road (SH 29 -B) from Km. Ch. 0+000 to 26+600 (Total Length - 26.6 Km.)				
		4.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Shahganj-Barkheda Road (SH-29D) (Total Length - 18.70 Km.)				
		5.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Chhapiheda Nalkheda Road Total Length 12.6 Km (Total Length - 12.60 Km.)				
		6.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Jeerapur-Machalpur-Soyatkalan Road (SH-60) from Km. 0 to 31.00 (Total Length - 31.00 Km.)				
		7.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of MDR Basoda - Sironj Road from Km. 0 to 42.00 (Total Length - 42 Km.)				
		8.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of (SH 29) Vidisha-Ahmadpur road from Km. Ch. 0+000 to 20+460 (Total Length – 20.46 Km.)				
2.	Group-B Sagar & Jabalpur	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Road (Bina-Khimlasa-Malthone (SH-61) (Total Length – 36.66 Km.)	41.68	20.84	59,000/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Rahatgarh-Khurai-Khimlasa Road (SH-62) (Total Length – 43.60 Km.)				
		3.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Damoh-Pathriya-Garhakota Road (Total Length - 33 Km.)				
		4.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Hata-Patera-Kumhari Road (Total Length - 50.60 Km.)				
		5.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Chiraidongri-Kanha Road (SH-33A) (Total Length - 6.00 Km.)				
		6.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Katni-Vijayraghavgarh-Barhi Road (MDR) (Total Length - 51.28 Km.)				
		7.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Jabalpur-Patan-Shahpura Road (SH-21 & 21 A) (Total Length - 38.85 Km.)				
		8.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Umariya-Shahpura Road Section (SH-68) (Total Length - 50.80 Km.)				
		9.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Chabi-Shahpura Road Section (SH-68) (Total Length - 26.60 Km.)				
3.	Group-C Ujjain	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Agar-Sarangpur road from Km 0.0 to 51.24 (Total Length - 51.24 Km.)	25.37	12.69	59,000/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Astha-Kannod road (SH 70) from Km 3.5 to 45 (Total Length - 41.50 Km.)				
		3.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Manasa-Rampura-Bhanpura road (SH 07) from Km 0.0 to 45 (Total Length - 45 Km.)				
		4.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Sonkach-Gandharvapuri road (SH 17) from Km 0.0 to 11.6 (Total Length-11.60 Km.)				
4.	Group-D Dhar & Indore	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Rajpur-Palsud-Niwali Road (SH-37) from Km 0 to 42.17 (Total Length - 42.17 Km.)	21.88	10.94	59,000/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Sardarpur-Badnawar Road (SH-65) (Total Length - 43 Km.)				
		3.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Anjad-Julwaniya Road (SH-37A) from Km-131 to 160. (Total Length - 29 Km.)				
		4.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Thandla Kushalgarh Road (SH-26A) CH 0+00 to 4+00 Km. (Total Length-4 Km.)				
		5.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Nagda-Dhar gujri Road (SH-52) (Total Length - 19.50 Km.)				
		6.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Khalghat-Manawar Road (SH-36) (Total Length - 42.70 Km.)				
		7.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Indore-Depalpur Road (Total Length - 26.80 Km.)				
		8.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Mandleshwar-Kasrawad Road (Total Length - 10.80 Km.)				
		9.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Kothi-Sanawad-Road (Total Length - 7.60 Km.)				
5.	Group-E Chhindwara	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Seoni-Bypass Road (Total Length - 15.80 Km.)	20.71	10.35	59,000/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Seoni - Balaghat Road (SH-72) (Total Length - 87 Km.)				
6.	Group-F Shahdol & Rewa	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Chhuhiya-Ghati from KM 19/6 to KM 33/6 in Rewa-Beohari-Shahdol Road (SH-57) (Total Length - 14.05 Km.)	19.26	10.00	35,400/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Kotma-Jaithari-Rajendragram Road (SH-35) from KM 12/6 to KM 33/10 and KM 45/10 to KM 73/8 (Total Length - 48.97 Km.)				
		3.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Flexible Pavement of Tilwari-Hardi-Janakpur Road (SH-14) (Total Length - 52 Km.)				
		4.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Flexible Pavement of Sundara-Singhpur-Kothi-Jaitwara-Birsinghpur-Semaria Road (SH-13 Km 0 to 86.13 (Total Length – 86.13 Km.)				
7.	Group-G Gwalior - 1 & 2	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Mohna-Pohari Road (Total Length - 36 Km.)	14.24	10.00	35,400/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Aaron-Ashoknagar Road (Total Length - 11.80 Km.)				
		3.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Sirsod-Pichhore Road (Total Length - 31.24 Km.)				
		4.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Nadigaon-Seondha Road (Total Length - 22.14 Km.)				
		5.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Satanwar - Narwar Road (Total Length - 25.54 Km.)				
		6.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Ambah-Pinhat Road (Total Length - 23.11 Km.)				
		7.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Datia - Seondha Road (Total Length - 65 Km.)				
8.	(H) Narmada-puram	1.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Budhni - Itarsi Road (Old NH – 69) (Total Length - 12.50 Km.)	8.35	8.35	23,600/-	12 Months
		2.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Harda - Ashapur Road (Total Length - 17.00 Km.)				
		3.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Narmadapuram Pipariya Road (Total Length - 15.24 Km.)				
		4.	Short Term Maintenance Contract (STMC) of Pipariya-Matkuli-Pachmarhi Road (Total Length - 16.60 Km.)				

The dates for purchase, submission, etc. are mentioned in the key dates. Tender forms can be purchased online only upto 15:30 hrs. on 22.10.2026 from website www.mptenders.gov.in. The bidders have to submit the Technical bid as well as Financial Bid online only. The Addendum/Corrigendum (if any) shall only be published on the website of www.mptenders.gov.in only. If holiday is declared by Govt. of M.P. on the date of opening, the same will automatically be shifted to subsequent working days. MPRDC reserves the right to accept/reject any/all tenders without assigning any reason thereof.

M.P. Madhyam/127998/2026

MANAGING DIRECTOR

Houthi rebels reach strategic Red Sea port city in Yemen

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Iranian-backed Houthi rebels have entered Yemen's strategic Red Sea port city of Mokha, according to two residents, which could bring the rebels closer to targeting shipping through a critical waterway to the Red Sea.

Separately, an Israeli strike killed at least four people in northern Gaza, including two children. And Israel warned Iran of a "powerful response" if Tehran attacks, threatening it could target Iran's energy facilities in retaliation. If confirmed, the development is significant because taking the city would put the Houthis closer to their goal of targeting shipping through the Bab el-Mandeb, a crucial waterway linking the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Indian Ocean. Mokha is about 80 kilometres from the strait.

Mokha long had been held by forces aligned with Yemen's internationally recognised Government.

A resident, Amin al-Mohammdi, said the Houthis



entered Mokha and fanned out across intersections. All roads from the west coast leading to Mokha have been closed, and shops were shut, he said. Another resident, Mohamed Salem, reported seeing vehicles belonging to Houthi forces in the streets. The Houthis have fought a civil war with the country's internationally recognised Government that started in 2014. The fighting now threatens a fragile truce that took effect in 2022.

The Houthis recently made advances in the western province of Taiz, where Mokha is located, according to Ahmed al-

Mawazi, a trooper with the Yemeni armed forces, and Abdel Kader al-Sharabi, a member of the Saudi-backed forces supporting the Yemeni Government.

Both said the rebels had seized control of the al-Shaqira area, an important supply route connecting the city of Taiz, the provincial capital, and other inland areas to Yemen's western coast. Meanwhile, Yemeni Government forces launched airstrikes targeting Houthi reinforcements west of Taiz, they added.

Clashes also continued along Yemen's western coast, particularly in the

direction of the southern part of the key port city of Hodeida. The fighting has taken place near crucial supply routes. Houthi-controlled Al-Masirah TV claimed that Saudi-backed forces launched 40 airstrikes in recent hours in Taiz, Jawf, Hodeida and Marib provinces. The AP couldn't independently verify the claim. There was no immediate comment from the Government forces.

Two children were among the dead after Israel carried out a new strike in the northern Gaza community of Beit Lahiya, according to Shifa hospital, where the bodies were taken. The strike killed a husband and wife, alongside their two daughters, aged 8 and 12. "There is nothing that can justify Israel attacking this home," said Zuheir al-Heisami, a neighbour of the family, at the hospital. He said the strike happened at around 2 am. "These were two children and their parents that were killed while they were asleep."

India has estimated nuclear 190 warheads: Report

SAGAR KULKARNI

■ Washington

India's nuclear arsenal is estimated at 190 warheads, which includes 30 additional warheads for new missiles under production, according to a US nonprofit policy think tank.

The Federation of American Scientists (FAS) derived the estimates from analyses of a combination of open sources, state-originating data and commercial satellite imagery. "Based on available public information about its nuclear-capable delivery force structure and strategy, we estimate that India may have produced around 190 nuclear warheads," according to the article titled 'India's Nuclear Weapons – 2026' penned by

FAS Nuclear Information



Project Director Hans Kristensen.

India's nuclear arsenal includes over 160 warheads for operational launchers as well as additional warheads for new missiles in production, it said. The article, published on Wednesday, noted that India continued to modernise its nuclear arsenal, with several new weapon systems fielded in recent

years and several more under development to complement or replace existing nuclear-capable aircraft, land-based delivery systems, and sea-based systems. "We estimate that India may have produced enough military plutonium for 140 to 225 nuclear warheads and might have assembled up to 190. With more weapon systems in development, the country's warhead stockpile will likely increase further," it said. India adopted the no-first-use doctrine after the Pokhran-II nuclear tests in 1998 and continues to adhere to the policy. "India is committed to maintaining credible minimum deterrence and a posture of 'no first use' of nuclear weapons," the Government told Parliament recently. The FAS article said as of the beginning of 2026,

the International Panel on Fissile Materials estimated India to have produced approximately 730 kg (plus/minus about 170 kg) of weapon-grade plutonium.

"Assuming approximately four kilogramme of plutonium per warhead, this would theoretically be sufficient for producing anywhere between 140 and 225 nuclear warheads," it said.

However, it said the calculation comes with some caveats due to several uncertainties, such as the warhead designs India has produced. India's 1998 nuclear tests reliably validated a fission design, but the country's progress on boosted fission and thermonuclear weapon designs remains highly uncertain, the article said. (PTI)

IPF hosts Bihar minister to boost trade, investment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Dubai

Bihar's growing investment potential, industrial transformation and sporting ambitions took centre stage in Dubai as the Indian People's Forum (IPF) Bihar Council hosted a special interaction with Sushri Shreyasi Singh, Minister for Industries and Sports, Government of Bihar, at India Club.

The event brought together prominent members of the Bihar diaspora, business leaders, professionals, community representatives and senior Government officials to explore opportunities for investment, entrepreneurship, employment and stronger India-UAE partnerships. Bihar showcased its



investment potential to international investors. The event provided a platform to connect the State's investment opportunities directly with its global diaspora.

Welcoming the gathering, RK Mahto, Convenor, IPF Bihar Council, highlighted Bihar's rich heritage and emerging opportunities, stressing the need to build

meaningful partnerships with the diaspora. Jitendra Vaidya, President, IPF UAE, outlined IPF's initiatives and community impact and spoke about his long-standing association with Minister Shreyasi Singh.

Addressing the gathering, Shreyasi shared her personal journey, sporting achievements and experiences in

public life. She highlighted women's empowerment and outlined her vision for Bihar, focusing on industrial development, investment, employment, sports excellence and opportunities for the younger generation.

Kundan Kumar, IAS, Secretary, Department of Industries, Government of Bihar, complimented the Minister's vision with an overview of Bihar's economic and infrastructure transformation. He highlighted opportunities and progress across power and electricity, manufacturing, agriculture and agri-tech, construction, roads, airports and industrial infrastructure, giving the diaspora a practical perspective on the State's emerging investment proposition.

Pakistan: Makkah agreement is defensive, rules out expansion

SAJJAD HUSSAIN

■ Islamabad

Pakistan on Thursday termed the trilateral defence agreement with Saudi Arabia and Turkiye as a "defensive alliance" to ensure regional security primarily through deterrence and ruled out any quick expansion of the pact.

Pakistan, Turkiye and Saudi Arabia signed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement in Makkah on August 7. The pact establishes a framework for collective deterrence and stipulates that an armed attack against any one of the three countries would be regarded as an attack against all three. The trilateral agreement was primarily a "defensive alliance to ensure regional security primarily through deterrence," Foreign Office spokesperson Sajjad Haider Khan said at the weekly press briefing.

His remarks came two days after Defence Minister Khawaja Asif on Tuesday



Sajjad Haider Khan

said that an unprovoked aggression against any member state, or a spillover of the Yemen conflict into Saudi Arabia, could activate the collective-defence provisions of the agreement. The minister's warning came after Yemen's Houthis launched missile and drone attacks on Saudi Arabia on Tuesday, targeting cities and economic and energy infrastructure and injuring at least 73 civilians. When asked about the expansion of the alliance, the Foreign Office spokesperson said it was currently "not on the cards". "At this stage, there are no discussions regarding the expansion of the Makkah agreement," he said. (PTI)

25 killed in cargo ship fire in China’s Qingdao

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

At least 25 people were killed when a fire broke out on a foreign-flagged cargo ship undergoing repairs in the eastern Chinese port city of Qingdao, State media reported on Thursday.

The blaze started at around 11.15 am at the State-owned Qingdao Beihai shipyard, state broadcaster CCTV reported.

Twenty people were killed in the fire, State-run CGTN reported.

President Xi Jinping has given orders to step up search and rescue efforts, according to CCTV, a rare instance of instructions from the top leadership accompanying an accident report, the Hong Kong-based *South China Morning Post* reported.

Xi also called for a swift investigation into the cause of the fire and



to ensure prompt follow-up and victim support, the report said.

All regions and relevant departments must “draw profound lessons from the blaze”, tighten preventive measures and “resolutely curb major accidents to safeguard lives and property”, he was quoted as saying.

The blaze started just after 11 am at the Qingdao Beihai shipyard in Qingdao, Shandong province.

A photo released by state news agency Xinhua suggests the ship is the Liberia-flagged bulk carrier the Ocean Melody. According to the MarineTraffic website, the vessel is moored in Qingdao.

Premier Li Qiang had ordered emergency teams to “focus on rescuing trapped personnel and treating the injured”, while “preventing secondary disasters”, the CCTV report said.

He has directed the State Council to use the incident as a warning to further tighten safety production responsibilities across all localities and sectors, and to deepen inspections for risk hazards.

The Ministry of Emergency Management had sent a working group to the scene to guide rescue and investigation efforts. At the same time, provincial authorities in Shandong had mobilised resources to manage on-site operations, CCTV said.

Qingdao Beihai is a major shipyard managed by the China State Shipbuilding Corporation.

It specialises in commercial shipbuilding, ship repair and off-shore engineering.

The facilities are spread across 330 hectares (815 acres) along 9 km (5.6 miles) of coastline, the Post reported. (PTT)

Nepal floods death toll climbs to 1,377, search operations continue



SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

The death toll due to the flash floods in Nepal rose to 1,377 on Thursday as more bodies were recovered from the affected districts, while rescue and search operations continue for more than 5,000 missing people, authorities said. At least 364 bodies have been recovered from Chitwan district, 228 from Nawalparasi East, 222 from Nawalparasi West and 198 from Nuwakot, according to the National

Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA). Similarly, 178 bodies have been recovered from Rasuwa, 77 from Gorkha, 70 from Dhading and 38 from Tanahu, it said. Two flood victims died during treatment in Kathmandu. The joint command of security personnel has continued search and rescue operations for the missing people, estimated to be 5,130.

So far, 13,656 people have been rescued from the flood-affected areas. (PTI)

Rubio hails Ecuador as key ally in US counterdrug fight

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Quito

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio hailed Ecuador as being the most “aggressive” partner in the Trump administration’s push to crack down on drug trafficking and transnational criminal groups in the Western Hemisphere.

Rubio was in Quito on the second leg of a three-nation tour of South America aimed at boosting security cooperation with conservative leaders who have cozied up to President Donald Trump.

Rubio met with Ecuadorian President Daniel Noboa, who



Ecuador’s President Daniel Noboa and US Sec of State Marco Rubio hold a document at Carondelet palace in Quito, Ecuador AP

has rapidly embraced the Trump administration’s get-tough stance on counternar-

cotics operations and illegal immigration. Rubio told reporters that “elite forces”

from both countries “are working jointly on a day-to-day basis in a way that has no precedent in order to try to dismantle these terrorist organisations”.

He announced his latest foreign terrorist organisation designation of a Latin American drug trafficking ring: Ecuador’s Los Tiguerones. It was among 22 criminal gangs designated as “terrorists” by Ecuador in 2024 after it declared an internal armed conflict during a surge in violence that included gunmen storming a television station during a live broadcast.

Death toll rises to 16 in landslides in China

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

Searchers in southeastern China have found another body from rain-triggered landslides last weekend in Jiangxi province, raising the death toll to 16, state media said on Thursday.

The deaths were spread across three towns in Suichuan county, where heavy rain drenched the area for days after Typhoon Saudel came ashore on China’s east coast. A mudslide in Gaoping town killed



13 people, state broadcaster CCTV said in an online report. Two others were found dead in Zuo’an town, and one other in Tanghu town. More than 18,000 people have been evacuated in Suichuan County.

Trump promises \$5,000 to every US adult if Republicans win midterm poll

JONATHAN J COOPER ■ Phoenix

President Donald Trump pledged to send every American adult \$5,000 if Republicans retain control of the House and Senate in the midterm elections, an extraordinary gambit to reverse his party’s sagging fortunes in November.

The dubious promise would likely cost more than



\$1 trillion and require congressional approval, and would further exacerbate the country’s nearly \$1.8 trillion annual budget deficit and concerns about inflation.

“If the Republicans win, you win with us and you get \$5,000,” Trump said during the GOP’s midterm convention in Dallas. “It will be called the Trump Dividend.” He likened the payments

to a corporation’s distributions to shareholders, citing “our tremendous strength and success economically.”

Within an hour, Vice President JD Vance appeared to try to walk back Trump’s proposal — at least in part — by suggesting the dividend payments would not go to the wealthy.

Vance suggested it could be paid for by US tariff revenues, though the suggested

payment dwarfs what the US has taken in through the protectionist measures. The White House did not respond to a message seeking details.

Congress would need to approve or otherwise acquiesce to the payment.

The sum would far exceed US tariff revenues even before the Supreme Court tossed much of the president’s tariff programme last year. (AP)

ELEONORE HUGHES ■ Rio De Janeiro

Brazil President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva signed a decree and a provisional measure aimed at lowering fuel prices, weeks ahead of the presidential election and as the US-Iran war drives up the cost of filling the tank. The cost of fuel is a particularly sensitive issue for voters, who will decide in October whether to grant Lula a fourth, nonconsecutive term, or elect Sen Flavio Bolsonaro, son of former president Jair

Bolsonaro. Brent crude, the international standard, surged above the \$100 threshold on Wednesday for the first time since July, after attacks on oil facilities and ships in the Middle East threatened to further strain an already weakened supply chain.

“We’re not going to allow this irresponsible war to hit your pocket,” said Lula as he signed the measures, which extend policies to control fuel prices introduced at the beginning of the US-Iran war. (AP)

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Registered Office of RPL AUTOMATION PRIVATE LIMITED (CIN: U72100 DL2000PT106465) has shifted from A-46 B, PANDEV NAGAR, DELHI, Delhi, India, 110092 to Plot No. A-34/2/8, Site-4, Industrial Area, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad-201010 (U.P.) w.e.f. Aug 30, 2026. All future correspondence and business operations will be handled from the new Ghaziabad address. For RPL AUTOMATION PRIVATE LIMITED VINOD KUMAR PANDEY Director Contact: 9811007100

PUBLIC NOTICE

V3 CHIT FUND INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED CIN: U74999DL2013PTC369019 Registered Office: Shop No. 7, Arya Samaj Mandir, Ramesh Nagar, New Delhi-110015 Corporate Office: F/227, 1st Floor, Mansarovar Garden, New Delhi-110015

The Company V3 Chit Fund India Private Limited have applied for De Registration of the Company, from Chit Fund. Public Objection if any, File with Registrar of Chit Fund Delhi within 15 Days. sd/- Ved Parkash Chopra Director

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to the public at large that Mrs. Preeti Sehgal had acquired Entire Third Floor with roof rights covered area 1331.495 sq. ft. on Plot No. 1402, at Sector-B, Measuring 203 sq. yds, Part of khasra No. 71/17, at Greenfields, Village Sarai Khawaja Tehsil Badkhal & Distt. Faridabad vide Sale Deed dt. 04.09.2025 executed by M/s. MPS Associates through its partner (1) Mr. Sanjay Goyal (2) Mr. Mohi Kalia (50% share) and Mr. Sahil Budhinga (50% share). Now Mrs. Preeti Sehgal is the undisputed owner of above said property and willing to Mortgage the above said property with CIFCL.

Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her/their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address: After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client. Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vilhar, Lalpat Nagar 4, New Delhi -110024

PUBLIC NOTICE

The General Public is hereby informed by way of present public notice that my clients Sh. Ibrahim S/o Noor Mohammad and Shahnaz W/o Mr. Ibrahim, both R/o 402, H-Block, JJ Colony, Sawda, Kanjhawala, Delhi-110081, have severed their all relationship, disowned and disinherited their daughter Ms. Mehndi from all their movable and immovable properties due to the fact that their daughter is not in speaking terms with our clients and her acts and conduct are not in consonance with the requirement of their family. She has even renounced her religion. Anybody dealing with Ms. Mehndi shall do so at his/her/their own risk and responsibilities and my clients will not be responsible for any acts, deed or dealing done by Ms. Mehndi. Dated: 10.09.2026 Deepak Kumar Mishra (Advocate) Ch. No. 284, Patiala House Courts, New Delhi-110001

सूचना

सर्व साधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि जिला नूह खण्ड इंस्टी के ग्राम पंचायत नौसेरा में नोरंग वाला मोहल्ला व बक वाले जोहड़ के पास पानी का बूस्टर पर पम्प चालक की नियुक्ति होनी है जो भी इच्छुक उम्मीदवार अपना नामांकन जमा कराना चाहते हैं व दिनांक 12.09.2026 से 19.09.2026 तक खण्डकार्यालय इंस्टी व ग्राम पंचायत नौसेरा के पास जमा करा सकते हैं। सरपंच चुकी ग्राम पंचायत नौसेरा खण्ड इंस्टी व जिला नूह, मो. 9813663492

NORTHERN RAILWAY e-OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE	
Name of work with location, cost of work and Earnest money	Balance work in connection with Elimination of Level Crossing No.44 on JHI-PNP section under ADEN/PNP and Balance work for completion of RUBs in the section of ADEN/KUN on DUK section. Approx. Cost : 9,27,30,434.80/-
Earnest Money	Rs. 18,54,600/-
Completion Period	09 Months.
Date and time of submission of tender and opening of tender	Upto 15:00 hrs on 06.10.2026 , Opening of e-tender after 15:00 hrs on 06.10.2026 .
Website particulars, published-tender, notice location etc. complete details of tender can be seen and website where the tender form can be downloaded	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
Similar nature of work / Any civil work other than track work.	
No. -128/W/280/Tender Notice/26-27/W4 (NIT-47) Dated: 10.09.2026 3136/2026	
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE	

E File No. 839536/DFA/1961883

PRESS NOTICE

The Director of Agriculture, Assam, Khanapara, Guwahati-22 invites BIDs vide NIT No. **E-839536/DFA/11960446** for "Construction & Establishment of Farmers Resource Centre at Oujari Progeny Orchard, District - Morigaon under PM-RKVY, 2026-27 with a Bid validity of 180 (One hundred and Eighty) days from the date of opening of the BIDs in 2 (Two) bid system, i.e, Technical Bid & Financial Bid) from registered Contractor/Firm (Class -I) under Agriculture Department Details of BID may be seen in the e-portal <[assamtenders.gov.in](http://www.assamtenders.gov.in)> The Bidders must be registered with the E-tendering system (ETS) of the Govt. of Assam. (Website: <http://www.assamtenders.gov.in>) All terms and conditions detailed in the Bidding documents.

sd/-
Director of Agriculture
Govt. Of Assam
DIPR/CF/PIO/1557/11-Sep-26
Khanapara,Guwahati-22

STATE BANK OF INDIA

HOME LOAN CENTRE-CUM-SARC II, CORRENTHUM BUILDING, GROUND FLOOR, SECTOR-62, NOIDA, DISTT.- GAUTAM BUDDH NAGAR, U.P.-201301

PHYSICAL AUCTION NOTICE FOR SALE OF MOVABLE PROPERTY ON 15.09.2026

Physical Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 15.09.2026 from 10:00 AM to 16:00Hrs. for recovery of Rs.4,18,875.00 (Rupees Four Lakh Eighteen Thousand Eight Hundred Seventy Five Only) as on 08.06.2026 plus other applicable charges, thereafter due to the secured creditor from MRS. NAMITA MEHTA. The Reserve Price will be Rs.3,00,000/- (Rupees Three Lakh Only) (*GST as applicable) and the Earnest Money Deposit will be Rs.30,000/- (Rupees Thirty Thousand Only) Demand Draft in favour of State Bank of India.

Date and Time of EMD Deposit on 14.09.2026 before 16:00 Hrs. The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 14.09.2026 From 11:00 AM to 16:00 Hrs.

VEHICLE DESCRIPTION	
Make & Model	MARUTI CELERIO VXi CNG (Petrol / CNG)
Registration No.	UP16CS9334
Engine No.	K10BN8429374
Chassis No.	MA3ETDE1S00728728
Date of Registration	28.12.2020
Kilometer Run	68427
Fuel	Petrol / CNG
VEHICLE AUCION PLACE	
ADDRESS: G-27, FLAT NO.104, PANKAJ TOWER, 4 DDA COMMUNITY CENTER, VIKAS PURI, WEST DELHI-110018	
For any queries please contact: (KUBER CONSULTANT) (Resolution Agent) (Mr. Rahul Pal, Mob: 9810807622)	

Date: 10.09.2026 Sd/- Jyoti Priya, Chief Manager/Authorized Officer, Place: NOIDA State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, RACP 2, Noida

STATE BANK OF INDIA E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

SME CENTRE A 2/2, SECTOR-52, 4TH FLOOR, (P.B.B. BRANCH) NOIDA-201301 DISTRICT-GAUTAMBUDHA NAGAR (U.P.)

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 13.10.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 13.10.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under :-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 13.10.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.					
S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property/ies is/are being sold	Description of Stock/ Plant & Machinery	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
1.	Assakka Food And Beverages Pvt. Ltd. Director:-1: Mrs. Rajeshwari W/o Omkarneshwara Reshmi, Director:-2: Avinash	Rs. 13,90,064.00 plus future Interest and other Charges etc. thereon	Hypothecation of Movable Asset 1. All Plant & Machinery purchased out of Bank's Finance. 2. A Tea Packing Machine & also for packing of Spices Products.	₹ 1,50,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST Inclusive	(Chief Manager) SME Centre A2/2, Sector-52 4th Floor, (P.B.B. Branch), Noida Mr. C. B. Dubey (Resolution Agent) Mobile: 9289074371

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 13.10.2026 before 9:00 A.M. Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPPESK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

- TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:
- E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
 - Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
 - The Plant and Machinery are available for inspection during banking hours on 12.10.2026 From 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM., Contact Person: Mr. C. B. Dubey, Mob. No.: 9289074371, DSA Associates (Resolution Agent) Address: East Kidwai Nagar Market, South Extension Part-1, New Delhi.
 - To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/ights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid. The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/dues.
 - The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property/ amount.
 - For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>

Date: 10.09.2026 Place: Noida Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, SME Centre A 2/2, Sector-52, Noida

STATE BANK OF INDIA E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

SME CENTRE A 2/2, SECTOR-52, 4TH FLOOR, (P.B.B. BRANCH) NOIDA-201301 DISTRICT-GAUTAMBUDHA NAGAR (U.P.)

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 25.09.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 25.09.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under :-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 25.09.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.					
S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property/ies is/are being sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
1.	Mr. Pankaj Kumar Singh C/o Umesh Prasad Singh	Rs.4,44,883.00 plus future Interest and other Charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: MARUTI SUZUKI INDIA LTD. WAGON-R VXi -CNG (PETROL / CNG) Registration No.: UP16LT3082 Engine No.: K10CNC416624 Chassis No.: MA3JMTB1SPH960075 Date of Registration: 13.09.2023 Kilometer Run: 15857 KM	₹ 2,55,000.00 ₹ 25,500.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST Inclusive	(Chief Manager) SME Centre A2/2, Sector-52 4th Floor, (P.B.B. Branch), Noida Mr. C. B. Dubey (Resolution Agent) Mobile: 9289074371

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 25.09.2026 before 09:00 A.M. Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPPESK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

- TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:
- E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
 - Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
 - The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 23.09.2026 From 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM., Contact Person: Mr. C. B. Dubey, Mob. No.: 9289074371, DSA Associates (Resolution Agent) Address: East Kidwai Nagar Market, South Extension Part-1, New Delhi.
 - To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/ights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid. The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/dues.
 - The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property/ amount.
 - For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>

Date: 10.09.2026 Place: Noida Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, SME Centre A 2/2, Sector-52, Noida

SCL Das takes charge as DERC chairman



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Newly appointed chairman of Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) SCL Das was on Thursday administered the oath of office by State Power Minister Ashish Sood.

The minister congratulated Das on assuming the new responsibility and expressed hope that his extensive administrative experience would greatly benefit the power sector in Delhi.

Delhi Government accords the highest priority

to transparency, accountability and protection of consumer interests in the power sector, Ashish Sood said in a statement.

Former IAS officer Subhash Chandra Lal Das was appointed DERC chairman through a notification issued on Wednesday.

Also, Ajay Kumar Jain, a retired district judge, was appointed as member (legal) and Praveen Gupta, as member (non-legal) of the Commission.

The post of DERC chairman was lying vacant for more

than a year. In a clean break from tradition, a retired IAS officer, instead of any retired High Court judge, has been given charge of the office.

Das's extensive experience and administrative expertise are expected to further strengthen and enhance the effectiveness of DERC's functioning, the statement said.

The DERC plays an important role in regulating the electricity sector in Delhi, safeguarding the interests of consumers and overseeing key matters related to electricity distribution.

Philippines looks beyond rice, eyes Telangana seeds and meat products

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Telangana's emerging trade partnership with the Philippines is poised to move beyond rice, with the Southeast Asian nation evincing keen interest in importing high-quality seeds and meat products from the State, Irrigation and Civil Supplies Minister Capt. N. Uttam Kumar Reddy said.

Following a meeting in New Delhi with Philippines Secretary of Agriculture Francisco P. Tiu Laurel Jr., Uttam Kumar Reddy said the discussions had opened up prospects for a much wider agricultural trade relationship.

"The Philippines has shown keen interest not only in purchasing more rice from Telangana but also in sourcing high-quality seeds and meat products. This could develop into a significant and diversified agricultural trade partnership," he said.

Significantly, the Philippines has indicated its willingness to procure additional quantities of Telangana rice at a competitive price. The price is considered among the best Telangana has secured for its rice in the export.

Uttam Kumar Reddy said the Philippines now offered considerable potential for scaling up Telangana's rice exports, given the



country's large and continuing dependence on imported rice.

Philippine rice consumption was estimated at around 17.6 million metric tonnes (MMT) in 2025-26. Its domestic paddy production, estimated at about 19.52 MMT, translates into a substantially smaller quantity after milling, leaving a gap between domestic rice availability and consumption.

The scale of the opportunity is reflected in the country's imports. The Philippines imported about 2.38 MMT of rice from different countries during January-May 2026 alone, around 16.5 per cent higher than in the corresponding period of the previous year.

Against this backdrop, Uttam Kumar Reddy said Telangana was positioning itself as a reliable and

competitive supplier to the Philippine market. Sustained exports could provide a major alternative market for the State's surplus rice while benefiting farmers and the rice-milling industry.

The Minister said the latest discussions were particularly encouraging because they had widened from a rice-specific engagement into a broader agricultural trade dialogue.

Telangana has a strong seed industry and significant capabilities in food and meat processing. Access to the Philippine market could therefore create new opportunities for farmers, seed companies, rice millers, meat processors and other agri-based industries in the State.

Uttam Kumar Reddy said the State Government's objective was to secure stable international markets rather than depend solely on occasional export opportunities.

Expanding Telangana's agricultural footprint in countries such as the Philippines would strengthen the farm-to-export value chain, improve market opportunities for producers and encourage further investment in processing and value addition, he said.

During the meeting, the Philippines Agriculture Secretary was invited to visit Hyderabad and participate in the Telangana Rising Summit scheduled for December 2026.

Swarovski Foundation launches new programme cycle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Swarovski Foundation's Creatives For Our Future programme, in collaboration with the United Nations Office for Partnerships, has opened applications for its latest cycle. The programme aims to identify and support young creative leaders developing innovative solutions for sustainable development.

Young creatives aged 21 to 30 from disciplines including fashion, design, art, architecture and engineering can apply until 9 November 2026. Applicants should be working on an original project or product that uses creativity, technology or innovative solutions to advance awareness and progress towards the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Selected participants will receive a \$20,000 grant, along with training, one-on-one mentorship and industry networking opportunities to help develop and scale their projects.

Since its launch in 2021, the programme has received more than 2,000 applications from 92 countries and supported 27 creative innovation projects across five cycles.

Maika Nakaoka, Head of Creativity at the Swarovski Foundation, said the programme is committed to supporting emerging creatives as agents of positive change and advancing new approaches to social and environmental challenges.

Lucie Brigham, Chief of Operations, UN Office for Partnerships, said design can transform bold ideas into innovative, sustainable and inclusive solutions.

DEPwD, ALIMCO, EkStep join hands to bridge digital divide for divyangs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A new digital architecture is set to bring Persons with Disabilities (PwDs) and the opportunities, services and support they need closer than ever. The Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD), Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment, Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India (ALIMCO) and EkStep Foundation, Bengaluru, on Thursday signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) in New Delhi to establish an institutional framework for the design, development, implementation and scaling of the Purple Dots — UBI (Unified Benefits Interface) initiative.

Conceptualised by DEPwD, the Purple Dots Initiative seeks to address a fundamental challenge in disability inclusion—not merely the availability of benefits and services, but the ability of a person to discover the right opportunity, service or support at the right time and place. At its core, a "Purple Dot" is a simple digital profile through which a Person with Disability can indicate who they are and what they need—whether it is employment, assistive technology such as a wheelchair, skill development, training or any other support. Similarly, employers, service providers, NGOs, philanthropic organisations and other institutions can create their own "dots" to indicate the opportunities, services and resources they offer.

By bringing these dots together through an open and interoperable digital infrastructure,

the initiative seeks to create a connected ecosystem in which needs and opportunities can discover each other locally and efficiently. An open digital protocol will enable ecosystem stakeholders to interact and respond to identified needs in real time, helping move disability inclusion from fragmented access towards seamless discovery, linkage and participation.

The MoU establishes a collaborative framework for taking the Purple Dots - UBI (Unified Benefits Interface) Initiative from concept to implementation and scale. It envisages enabling Persons with Disabilities to discover and connect with relevant government entitlements, services, employment opportunities, training programmes, assistive devices

and support systems offered by Government Departments, private-sector entities, civil society organisations, NGOs, philanthropic institutions and other ecosystem partners.

EkStep Foundation, a philanthropy instrumental in conceiving and architecting Digital Public Infrastructure/ Digital Public Good initiatives for large-scale societal transformation, is partnering with DEPwD and ALIMCO to bring its experience of building open and collaborative digital ecosystems to the disability sector.

The collaboration brings together the mandate and nationwide reach of DEPwD, the experience and capabilities of ALIMCO in the disability sector, and EkStep Foundation's experience in enabling ecosystem-led

digital innovation at scale.

The ceremony was attended by Manmeet Kaur Nanda, Additional Secretary; Ashish Thakre, Director; Pradeep A., Director; and Sandeep Kumar, Under Secretary, from DEPwD. From ALIMCO, Pankaj Dwivedi, Assistant Manager, and Priya Grover, Assistant Manager, were present. Ikpreet Singh, Director; Gaurav Gupta represented EkStep Foundation, Bengaluru.

The Purple Dots Initiative envisages a future in which a person's need does not remain invisible and an available opportunity does not remain undiscovered—where digital connectivity becomes a practical bridge between Persons with Disabilities and the ecosystem of services, opportunities and support around them.

Vision to Impact CSR Conclave brings leaders together for social change

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

People for Action hosted the first edition of the Vision to Impact CSR Conclave 2026in New Delhi on Wednesday, bringing together representatives from Government, business, civil society, education, healthcare, culture and digital media to discuss collaborative approaches to social responsibility and sustainable impact.

The conclave was attended by Jayant Chaudhary, Minister of State (Independent Charge), Ministry of Skill Development & Entrepreneurship, and Minister of State for Education, as Chief Guest. Addressing the gathering,



Chaudhary highlighted the role of collaboration in translating CSR initiatives into lasting social impact. He said platforms such as Vision to Impact can help bring together the strengths of industry, Government and civil society to address pressing social challenges and contribute to building a more inclusive and empowered India.

The event featured five

thematic panels focusing on health, education, art, inclusion and social media, along with keynote and special sessions on leadership, empowerment, cybersecurity and nation-building.

People for Action founder Afsana Cherian Kapoor said the conclave was created to connect individuals and organisations working towards social change.

GDA demolishes illegal colony in Muradnagar area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

On 10 September 2026, under the leadership of the Officer-in-Charge, Enforcement Zone-2, a demolition action was carried out by Anurag Garg and Pankaj Chaudhary against an illegal colony being developed over approximately 11,000 square metres at Khasra No 322, Village Mohaddinpur, Hisali-Kanoja Road, Muradnagar, and Ghaziabad.

During the inspection, it was found that illegal plotting had been carried out at the site. The developers had also encroached upon and incorporated drainage land into the illegal plotting. No valid approval or land records were produced at the site.

The construction/development work was stopped, and demolition proceedings were subsequently carried out against the illegal development.



During the demolition operation, local builders and colonisers strongly opposed the action. However, the GDA Police Force brought the situation under control, allowing the demolition operation to continue smoothly.

The demolition action was carried out in the presence of the Assistant Engineer, Junior Engineer,

and the entire staff of Enforcement Zone-2, GDA Police Force, and the GDA Enforcement Squad.

The GDA has stated that the campaign against unauthorised construction and illegal colonies will continue, with demolition and sealing actions to be carried out at other such sites in the coming months as well.

Chhattisgarh clears ₹500 cr startup, NIPUN mission

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

The Chhattisgarh Government has taken two important decisions for the State's youth and business community. At the Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai, the Government approved the ₹500-crore 'Chief Minister Startup and NIPUN Mission' for the next five years, along with the 'Chhattisgarh Export Promotion Policy 2026-30'.

The Startup Mission will directly benefit the State's youth. Entrepreneurship Development Centres will be

established in all 33 districts, along with 100 Emerging Technology Labs and 5 Industry Excellence Centres.

These facilities will help young people develop their business ideas, learn new technologies and turn their ideas into viable businesses within their own districts. Through the NIPUN JOB Engine, youth will receive training based on industry requirements, creating better employment opportunities. The mission aims to help young people move beyond being job seekers and become entrepreneurs who create jobs for others.



Central Bank becomes first PSU bank to launch Bharat Connect for Business



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Central Bank of India has become the first Public Sector Bank to launch 'Bharat Connect for Business', in partnership with NPCI Bharat BillPay Ltd (NBBL), marking a significant step towards strengthening India's digital B2B payments ecosystem.

The platform provides an

integrated digital ecosystem for businesses to generate invoices, make and receive payments, manage collections and settlements, enabling secure, seamless and efficient transactions between buyers, sellers and their banks.

The initiative was launched at the NPCI Pavilion at Global Fintech Fest 2026 in the presence of Kalyan Kumar, MD & CEO, Central

Bank of India, and Noopur Chaturvedi, MD & CEO, NBBL.

The initiative is expected to further support MSMEs and businesses by simplifying digital transactions and enabling greater efficiency through technology-led financial solutions. It also reinforces Central Bank of India's commitment to contributing to a stronger digital payments ecosystem and the vision of Viksit Bharat.

Acharya Prashant's philosophical framework delves into life

DEEPAK KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

The "AP Framework" comes from Acharya Prashant, founder of the PrashantAdvait Foundation and named by Watkins' Mind Body Spirit magazine among its 100 Most Spiritually Influential Living People. It is an attempt to organise his insights on self-inquiry and human suffering into a clear philosophical structure.

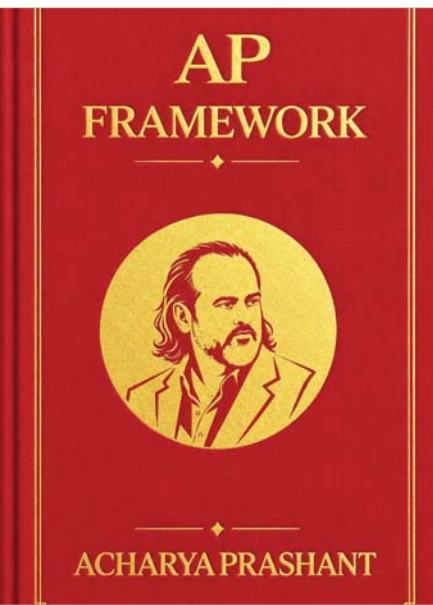
Unlike most contemporary spiritual works, which are often collections of talks or conversations, the AP Framework is a deliberately organised, book-length work. It covers seven major areas of philosophy and includes an extensive glossary of specialised terms.

The framework also has a practical digital expression in AP Mirror, an LLM-based application designed to bring its method of self-inquiry into personal situations. Rather than simply supplying answers, the Mirror questions the assump-

tions behind a user's problem and attempts to expose patterns of self-deception. In the framework's own terms, technology can assist with seeing, but it cannot supply intent: the willingness to actually change remains with the individual.

This analysis examines what the framework says about itself, how its main ideas work, where it differs from major Eastern and Western philosophies, and where its own arguments face their greatest difficulties. Interestingly, the framework itself recognizes many of these difficulties and attempts to answer them. The AP Framework is a rigorous and largely non-mystical philosophy of self-inquiry. It begins not by telling us what God, Brahman or ultimate reality is, but by examining the one who wants answers: the ego.

Its most distinctive move is to remove many of the consolations offered by both traditional mysticism and modern rationalism. At the same time, the framework does something relatively unusual for a system-



atic philosophy: it explicitly identifies weaknesses and unresolved questions within its own structure. It does not claim that every difficulty has disappeared merely because it has been named.

For this reason, the AP Framework may best be understood not as a final theory of reality, but as a disciplined experiment in self-inquiry. One of the most unusual things about the framework appears right at the beginning: it denies that Acharya Prashant himself has created a philosophical "system."

The text calls itself a "listener-side artifact." In other words, students have organised ideas found across AP's talks and writings into a coherent structure. The framework therefore places itself below the living teaching.

Another important distinction is between the ego and the mind. The framework treats the mind as a biological instrument consisting broadly of memory and intellect.

E-Tender Notice

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY,
AMRITSAR

SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Computer for Auto CAD and GIS Lab be submitted online latest by **17/09/2026 upto 4:00 p.m.** Detailed information can be obtained from website **www.eproc.punjab.gov.in**. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: **eproc.punjab.gov.in**

2426/12/2026-27/15019 Dated CHD :- 10/09/2026

Registrar

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
PARADIP-754142, ODISHA (INDIA)
(An autonomous body under Ministry of Ports, Shipping & Waterways, Govt. of India)
No. AD/RSC-II/21/27/2024 (PI)/2747 Dated, the 07th September, 2026

Advertisement

Applications are invited from Indian Nationals for engagement of Assistant Manager (Welfare) (Class-II) on Direct Recruitment basis in Paradip Port Authority. For further details, visit our website **https://paradipport.gov.in/Career.aspx**.
PPA/PR/25/2026-2027
08/09/2026

Dy. Secretary
Paradip Port Authority

BRIEFLY

No sports background: Sufiya eyes Ladakh ultra marathon



Long-distance runner Sufiya Sufi is brimming with confidence as she prepares to defend her Ladakh Silk Route Ultra Marathon title, with her sights set on winning this year's race in record time.

A five-time Guinness World Records holder in long-distance running, Sufi is upbeat about her chances and says her familiarity with Ladakh gives her added confidence ahead of the race. Her Guinness records include an ultra run from Kashmir to Kanyakumari in 2019, the 6,000-km Golden Quadrilateral challenge in 2020, three runs from Manali to Leh, a run across Qatar and, most recently, a 5,000-km run from Kanyakumari to the Karakoram Pass.

"Ladakh is close to my heart because it's been more than five years I'm coming to Ladakh, doing my own running challenges and it's been three years I'm doing Silk Route Ultra and last year I was a winner. I am very optimistic and eager to defend my title," Sufi said.

(PTI)

Torres makes PSG history with hat trick in Champions League



Just arrived at Paris Saint-Germain, Ferran Torres is already setting records. The World Cup final hero for Spain, Torres scored a hat trick in PSG's 6-1 rout of Slovan Bratislava in the Champions League late Wednesday. He's the first player in the club's history to score three goals in his first Champions League match.

Torres is also the first player to score during his Champions League debut with PSG since Neymar and Kylian Mbappe against Celtic Glasgow on Sept. 12, 2017.

Titleholder PSG bolstered its star-studded attack by signing Torres from Barcelona on a five-year contract this summer. The 26-year-old forward scored Spain's winning goal during extra time of the World Cup final against Argentina in July. It was his only goal of the tournament and he said it was "scored by 47 million people," referring to Spain's population.

(AP)

India storm into women's junior Asia Cup semis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Moqi (China)

India stormed into the semi-finals of the Women's Junior Asia Cup with a ruthless 19-0 demolition of Pakistan here on Thursday.

India dominated from start to finish, producing a relentless attacking display to register one of the biggest wins of the tournament. India scored 19 goals, earned 18 penalty corners and one penalty stroke, while Pakistan were unable to register a goal, penalty corner or penalty stroke.

India will face the winners of Korea and Malaysia in the semi-final on Saturday.

India dominated the contest from the opening whistle, scoring five goals in the first quarter, adding five more in the second, three in the third and another six in the final quarter to register a comprehensive win and book their place in the last four.

India won two penalty corners within the opening five minutes, although they were unable to convert either opportunity.

Their sustained pressure soon



paid off when they found the back of the net in the sixth minute, only for the goal to be disallowed following a referral.

India continued to press and were awarded another penalty corner a minute later. Puja Sahoo made no mistake this time, converting in the seventh minute to give India a 1-0 lead. India quickly doubled their advantage when Roshni Aind scored a field goal in the ninth minute.

India's fourth penalty corner of the quarter resulted in another goal, with Tanushree Kadu scoring through a deflection in the 11th minute to make it 3-0.

Pakistan conceded a foul inside the circle, resulting in a penalty stroke.

Sukhveer Kaur calmly

converted from the spot in the 13th minute. India added another goal almost immediately, with Sanika Mane finding the back of the net with a field goal to make it 5-0 after first quarter.

Madhu Sidar scored a field goal in the

16th minute before Geeta Yadav added another two minutes later to swell India's lead to 7-0.

Sanika scored again in the 23rd minute to complete her brace.

Tanuja Toppo then registered her first goal of the match in the 25th minute. India continued to win penalty corners and eventually converted another in the 27th minute, with Pooja Malik finding the target to make it 10-0 before the half-time break.

They showed no signs of slowing down as three minutes into the third quarter, another penalty corner resulted in a goal when Purnima Yadav scored through a deflection to make it 11-0.

India earned another penalty corner soon after, and Madhu found the target again in the 39th minute with a deflection.

Supriya then converted another penalty corner in the 40th minute to take India's tally to 13-0. Krishna Sharma scored her first goal of the tournament with a field goal in the 48th minute. A minute later, Pooja completed her brace. She was on target once more in the 51st minute, completing her hat-trick.

Flame lit in Athens for Africa's first ever Olympic event

DEREK GATOPOULOS/
PETROS GIANNAKOURIS
■ Athens

The flame for the Dakar Youth Olympics was lit in Athens on Thursday for the first Olympic competition ever staged in Africa. International Olympic Committee President Kirsty Coventry, the organization's first African and first female leader, said the moment carried profound personal meaning. "As African, this moment means so much to me," Coventry, an Olympic swimming champion from Zimbabwe, said, her voice breaking with emotion.

"For so many years we have spoken about the day when an Olympic event would finally come to our continent," she said. "And now we have that great honor." Sun's rays light the flame With a nod to Apollo, the ancient Greek god of truth, healing and the sun, the flame was kindled using a concave mirror that channels the sun's rays.

The hourlong ceremony was at the Panathenaic Stadium, the venue of the



first modern Olympics in 1896.

The Youth Games from Oct. 31-Nov. 13 bring together some 2,700 athletes aged 15-18 in 25 sports in the Senegalese capital, Dakar, and two other cities. Dakar organizing head Mamadou Diagna Ndiaye offered assurances the Games would be a success.

"We do not promise the perfect games. We promise real games, warm games," he said. Thursday's ceremony featured hip-hop dancers, cheerleaders, a youth choir and a performance by Senegalese singer Kya Loum.

(AP)

Vinicius Jr, Raphinha headline Brazil's star-studded squad for historic India clash



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Real Madrid forward Vinicius Junior, Barcelona winger Raphinha and Paris Saint-Germain veteran Marquinhos headline Brazil's 26-member squad for their historic first-ever meeting with India on October 3.

The Selecao will face India at the Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata at 7.30 pm local time, in what will be a landmark fixture for Indian football.

The match is scheduled after Brazil's two-game Australia tour, with Carlo Ancelotti's side facing the hosts in Townsville on September 25 and Brisbane on September 29.

Ancelotti named his first squad since the 2026 World Cup at the headquarters of the Brazilian Football Confederation (CBF) in Rio de Janeiro on Wednesday before addressing the media.

Vinicius, Raphinha and Marquinhos form the experienced core of the squad, with Arsenal's Gabriel Magalhaes and Bruno Guimaraes also retaining their places.

The much-anticipated game promises to be a grand spectacle for football-crazy Kolkata, with Brazil bringing three 2026 Ballon d'Or nominees in Vinicius, Marquinhos and Gabriel for their historic first meeting with India.

Ancelotti has called up several players who will also be eligible for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, while Marquinhos,

who captained Brazil at the 2026 World Cup, remains the most experienced member of the squad. The five-time champions were eliminated by Norway in the round of 16.

"We have to make a balanced list, with players who played in the last campaign and young players who can bring new energy to the team. The idea is to build something for the future without losing our competitiveness," said Ancelotti.

The most striking changes are likely to come at the back as Brazil have left out their World Cup goalkeeping trio of Alisson, Ederson and Weverton, with Corinthians' Hugo Souza taking over as the first-choice goalkeeper.

Coritiba's Pedro Morisco and Cruzeiro's Otavio have been named as his back-ups.

The defence has also been rejigged, with Arthur Dias, Jair, Matheuzinho and Mauro Junior included alongside more established players such as Marquinhos and Magalhaes.

The Brazil coach said the changes are part of a longer-term plan to build a side capable of competing at the 2030 World Cup, while maintaining the quality expected of the national team.



Anahat, Abhay face Malaysian challenge as Asian Games draw announced



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India's Abhay Singh has been awarded the second seed in the men's singles draw while trailblazer Anahat Singh has been seeded third in the women's singles as both players push for the gold medal in the Asian Games, also securing qualification for the 2028 Olympics in the process. The seedings, announced on Thursday, were prepared considering the world rankings by July 13.

While India have won three gold medals in the Asian Games, they are yet to step on the top of the singles podium.

Squash will make its Olympic debut in couple of years and the singles winners of the Asian Games earn direct qualification for the 2028 Summers Games in Los Angeles, raising the stakes significantly.

Anahat, India's first ever junior world champion, is expected to win a medal at the Asian Games if not the gold. The world number 20's main competitors include fifth ranked and defending champion Sivasangari Subramaniam from Malaysia and sixth ranked Satomi Watanabe

from Japan.

The 18-year-old had fallen short against Subramaniam in the London Classic quarterfinals recently. Tanvi Khanna is another Indian in the women's singles draw and has been seeded seventh.

In the men's singles draw, 24th-ranked Abhay has been given the second seed behind 18th ranked defending champion Eain Yow Mg from Malaysia. India's Veer Chotrani has been seeded fourth. Veteran Joshna Chinappa will be seen in action in mixed doubles and women's team events in her record seventh consecutive Asian Games appearance.

The Indian men's team comprising Abhay, Chotrani, V Senthilkumar and Suraj Kumar Chand has been awarded the top seed ahead of Malaysia, Pakistan and Hong Kong. The Anahat-led women's team has been seeded third. India had won won the men's team and mixed doubles gold in the previous edition in Hangzhou, China. Abhay was part of the winning men's team while the mixed doubles gold came via Harinder Pal Sandhu, who is now part of the coaching staff, and Dipika Pallikal.

DAILY SUDOKU

6			1			3	
		1	4				
	2			6	3	7	1
			8			4	5
7		5			9		8
9	3				1		
2		9	1	8			7
				5	6		
	8			2			1

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (10.9.26)

6	1	3	5	4	9	2	7	8
8	5	2	7	3	6	1	9	4
7	9	4	8	1	2	6	3	5
4	2	8	1	7	3	9	5	6
5	3	6	9	8	4	7	2	1
1	7	9	2	6	5	4	8	3
2	4	1	3	9	8	5	6	7
3	6	5	4	2	7	8	1	9
9	8	7	6	5	1	3	4	2

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | SEPTEMBER 11, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
8	9			10		
11		12				
13			14		15	16
		18		19		
20		21				
22					23	
			24		25	
26	27		28		29	30
31				32		33
			34			35
36					37	
						38

SOLUTION (10.9.26)

- ACROSS

1. Ca-MBE-r
7. Occident
8. DA-ta
10. T-win-ed
11. De-test
14. Ad-d
16. Fo-r-e
17. Duly
19. Scalp
21. Ferry

DOWN

22. Bream
23. S-kep-
26. Z-Airp
28. Fie
29. In-tact
30. Bunyan
31. Orbs (bros.)
32. Comp-lie
33. Sid-Les

DOWN

1. Carte-d
2. Brandy
3. Road
4. Firefly
5. Never
6. State
8.Dial
9. Ted
12. Top
13. Score
15. Sca-P
18. Urban

DOWN

19. See
20. Arm
21. Fre-ckle
22. Bra
23. Sin-bad
24. Keys
25. Ponies
26. Zilch
27.Items
28. Fur
30. Boss

ACROSS

4 Forgo a ticket to the top (4,2)
7 The nautical might of an AB? (3,5)
8 To do wrong with promises of money is nasty (6)
10 Is there a town like her, that bookish girl? (5)
13 Be patient, showing sense about an article (4)
14 A hasty sensitive reaction? (4)
15 Intends to produce a really good manuscript (4)
16 Like the weather in Crewe tomorrow (3)
17 Centrally placed to get help around the end of term (4)

DOWN

1 Any actress should love him (5)
2 Where a spare part is capital (5)
3 Grand individual no longer with us (4)
4 A half paid sort of golf championship? (3-2)
5 One taking turns to sit around the piano?
6 The sun rises in due style - absolutely fresh (6)
9 Field event the American gets on a plate?
11 As laid down in Delaware? (3)
12 Four-legged president? (5)
13 He alone gives a wider tour of the town centre (7)
15 Even to a first-class student, it means

19 Cold fellow getting dressed (4)
21 Conversations with a girl, a boy and some pedagogues (9)
23 What they called Hitler before the war
24 I sew in commendable style (4)
26 They're gentlemanly in many ways (3)
27 Sort of letter to take out of the envelope (4)
29 The farmer's creditable work (4)
32 An old enemy (4)
33 Land of mysterious machinations (5)
34 Figures there are still saints about (6)
35 Refuse to agree with "4 Across"! (4,4)
36 Tweedy fellow splitting hairs about what's right (6)

"trouble" (3)
16 Is no longer in Pugwash (3)
18 A colourful firework (6)
20 Creature said to be used in bleaching
21 The German lair? (3)
22 Drink with Joe North (3)
23 An insular, saintly female (6)
25 Over there in the Yukon, Britain excluded (3)
28 One can take steps to control them (5)
30 Tear ahead to town (5)
31 Noticeable new coat? (5)
32 Put up with the beast! (4)
33 Is such sugar sticky? (4)



East Zone clinch Duleep Trophy after 13 years

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Chennai

(PTI) East Zone translated their complete dominance over the last 12 sessions into a Duleep Trophy victory after 13 years, overwhelming South Zone on the basis of a massive first innings lead on the fifth and final day of the final here on Thursday.

East Zone sauntered to 388 for seven in their second innings, swelling the overall lead to 760 runs even as the match ended in a draw.

Mohammad Kounlian Quraishi joined the list of century-makers in this match with an unbeaten 116, his maiden three-figure mark in two-match-old first-class career.

Quraishi, who added 150 runs with Anukul Roy (64) for the seventh wicket stand, reached the milestone in 179 balls with a brace off left-arm pacer CV Milind.

But way before the teams shook hands at 2.10 pm signalling a draw, East had wrested the trophy after posting a mammoth 708 runs in their first innings, which helped them construct a 372-run lead.

East's second innings was a mere



continuation of their show of power in the match.

Starting the day from 212 for five, the Ishan Kishan-led side, as it happened in the first innings, was seldom troubled by direction-less South bowlers.

Seasoned Mohammed Siraj bounded in for a while, showing intensity and pace. While it was satisfactory from a personal point of view, the effort remained futile otherwise.

The lack of support for Siraj and a toothless batting effort also reflected the flawed selection as far as South squad is concerned.

The South management chose to ignore in-form and proven players such as Karun Nair, Mayank Agarwal and Sai Kishore and the replacements never really could step up.

But plenty of East Zone players did that. Skipper Kishan made a stunning 270

in the first innings to underline his red-ball readiness while veteran Mohammed Shami, who was playing in his 100th first-class match, put to shame some younger names with a spirited effort.

Kumar Kushagra scored his sixth first-class hundred while his Jharkhand teammate Shikhar Mohan made a fifty filled with class and poise. Above all, Kishan also showed impressive tactical awareness while leading East.

Once the team put on board a massive total, Kishan was clear in his primary objective – take 10 South wickets and get a first innings lead. The 28-year-old detailed his plan.

“I think when you are the captain of the team, the first thing is situational awareness. We batted for roughly two days, right? Now, as a unit, we know this is essentially a first-innings shootout,” Kishan said. (PTI)

Plenty of reasons to stay motivated as eyes must always be set on next level: Mohammed Shami

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Chennai

Mohammed Shami has not played for India since March 2025 but the veteran pacer on Thursday asserted that his motivation level has not dipped, and is still eyeing the “next level” in his career. Shami's last Test appearance was even further back during World Test Championship final against Australia in 2023.

“There are plenty of reasons to stay motivated if you look for them. At this level, if you aren't self-motivated, your approach is wrong. No matter what stage you're playing at, your eyes must always be set on the next level,” Shami said after the Duleep Trophy final in which East Zone defeated South Zone on the basis of first innings lead.

The 36-year-old took two important wickets of Ravichandran Smaran and Sheikh Rasheed to rock South's middle-order in the title clash here. It helped East wrap their rival's first innings for 336 and



gain a match-defining lead of 372 runs. Shami was delighted that East Zone's title win coincided with his 100th first-class game. “As far as satisfaction goes, achieving this in my 100th match-and that too in a winning Duleep Trophy final-is special. You've seen how we performed,” he said.

“Every single boy put his heart and soul into this campaign to get us here. To achieve this in these conditions, in this heat, is outstanding. As for me, whether it's your first match or your 100th, it doesn't matter-the effort and the approach remain exactly the

same,” he said.

But how does he find the grind in domestic cricket after spending well over a decade at the top-flight cricket?

“When you wear that crest on your chest, the level of cricket doesn't matter. If you play for the badge, that hunger will naturally show. Your willingness to fight only grows when you play with that pride.

“My mindset is simple: whichever level I get an opportunity to play, I want to make it count and fulfil my responsibility toward the team,” he said. One of those responsibilities is to mentor the younger

names in the squad, and Shami enjoyed it too.

“I thoroughly enjoyed it. The kid in our team (Vaibhav Sooryavanshi) is literally as old as my career. He has that youthful innocence, loves to joke around, and absorbs things quickly.”

Shami cautioned against meddling with young players' thoughts and game as they come up with a certain level of maturity. “But most of these youngsters are already quite mature. With the level of cricket they play today-featuring in the IPL and other high-pressure tournaments-maturity comes early, so you don't need to over-coach them.

“But yes, when the game gets tight and challenging, that's when you step in with tactical inputs and remind them to keep fighting,” he said. Playing the Duleep Trophy final in the oppressively humid Chennai climes would have been a massive challenge for a fast bowler, particularly at his age.

I am doing everything in my control to be ready for a Test call-up, says Arshdeep Singh

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

India pacer Arshdeep Singh understands quite well that his relatively low count of first-class appearances may not be considered “ideal preparation” as he pursues his Test dreams but he insists that it is in no way a reflection of his readiness for the traditional format. One of India's premier bowlers in the limited-overs format, Arshdeep has only played 24 first-class matches since his debut in December 2019.

The match Nos. 23 and 24 came in this season's Duleep Trophy. Before these games, Arshdeep had not played first-class cricket for nearly a year. He looked to make the most of the opportunity in the Duleep Trophy, where his team, North Zone, crashed out in the semifinal stage.

“I do everything that is within my control to be ready for the (Test) call-up,” Arshdeep, who joined his Sher-e-Punjab side Ludhiana Lions right after the Duleep Trophy, told PTI in an exclusive interaction.

“The long gaps in First-Class games may not be ideal for preparation, but I can only focus on the things I can do to be ready when I get the chance,” he said.

“Competing for the Test side is an



honour that I'm very much looking forward to, and I'm confident in my

ability to make a difference for India,” he insisted. The 27-year-old left-arm pacer said understanding the “mechanics” of his body while playing in the Duleep Trophy was one of the primary tasks he worked on.

“As a fast bowler, it is usually tough on the body to play first-class games that can sometimes be very demanding. But as a fast bowler, I also take immense pride in managing this workload and bringing out my best each time I run in to bowl,” Arshdeep said.

“The main learning has been to understand the mechanics of my own body and most importantly to listen to it when it comes to managing the limits of my own physicality. Recovery is extremely crucial,” said the two-time T20 World Cup winner.

Playing on spin-friendly tracks at Bengaluru's Centre of Excellence was another challenge, but one that Arshdeep said was crucial to overcome as a fast bowler. “I saw the challenge of bowling on spin-friendly tracks as a chance to hone my own skills to bowl in any track conditions,” he said of the pitches at COE. (PTI)

Yash replaces Harshit Rana for Afghanistan T20Is and Asian Games



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Yash Thakur on Thursday replaced injured fast bowler Harshit Rana, while pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah was cleared to play in India's upcoming T20I series against Afghanistan and the Asian Games.

Rana, who last played for India on the England tour, had been recovering from a hamstring injury at the BCCI Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru. However, he sustained a new injury – a thigh strain – while bowling during a match simulation on Monday.

“The fast bowler was progressing well during his rehab. He sustained a rectus femoris strain while bowling during a match simulation on September 7 and has subsequently been ruled out,” a BCCI media release said.

The 27-year-old Thakur from Vidarbha recently made his T20I debut during India's tour of Zimbabwe in July. He played two matches and took four wickets. He has featured in 50 Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy matches, picking up 81 wickets at an impressive economy rate of 7.04.

74th Inter Services Basketball Championship 2026-27 concludes, champions crowned



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The 74th Inter Services Basketball Championship 2026-27 concluded successfully at Mercury Stadium, Army Basketball Node, 1 Army Headquarters Signals Regiment in New Delhi following days of intense competition, unwavering determination and exemplary military sportsmanship.

Indian Army Red won the 74th Inter

Services Basketball Championship 2026-27 by defeating the Indian Air Force 81-50 in the final.

From fierce competition on the court to lasting camaraderie off it, the tournament showcased the spirit of jointmanship, excellence, discipline and service before self.

Lt Gen Vivek Dogra, SM, Signal Officer-in-Chief & Colonel Commandant, graced the Final as Chief Guest and

applauded all teams for their spirited performances and sporting excellence.

The event included one court, four teams, one champion and countless memories.

The successful conclusion of the 74th edition added another memorable chapter to services basketball, celebrating sporting excellence and strengthening bonds among the Armed Forces.

Delhi Cabinet approves ₹2,000 monthly aid for young athletes at grassroots level

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Chennai

The Delhi Cabinet on Thursday approved a new financial assistance scheme for young athletes training at government sports centres and stadiums. The government will provide ₹2,000 per month to eligible players under an expanded version of the Mukhyamantri Khel Protsahan Yojana (MKPY).

The decision, taken at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, introduces a “Grassroots Training Support Assistance” com-

ponent under MKPY. Eligible young athletes who regularly train at Delhi government sports centres and stadiums will now receive the monthly assistance, aimed at removing financial barriers that could otherwise disrupt training at an early stage.

The Chief Minister said the new assistance would help athletes cover regular expenses on nutrition, local travel, basic sporting equipment and medical needs during their formative years. She said the monthly support would allow them to continue training without interruption,



reducing dropout rates and helping government sports centres develop into stronger hubs for grassroots talent.

Under the scheme, assistance will be provided to up to 25 percent of the regularly enrolled trainees at each government sports centre or stadium, with a

cap of 100 athletes at any single facility under normal circumstances. At larger stadiums with higher enrolments, this limit may be raised to 150 athletes, subject to budget availability. The scheme covers athletes in the Under-14, Under-17, Under-19 and Under-21 age groups.

Beneficiaries will be selected based on sporting performance and potential, regular attendance and discipline, and financial need. Eligible athletes must maintain regular enrolment and at least 80 percent attendance to qualify for continued assistance. The Chief Minister said a structured selection process would be followed, with beneficiaries' performance, attendance and discipline reviewed every quarter to ensure the assistance reaches athletes who are training consistently and showing genuine poten-

tial to progress in their sport. The new grassroots component adds to the existing framework of MKPY. Under the scheme's Training Support module, top-ranked athletes at the school level receive assistance of up to ₹5 lakh per year for coaching, equipment, competition participation, nutrition and other training needs. Elite athletes representing Delhi and India at the highest level can receive up to ₹20 lakh annually.

Under Participation Support, eligible expenses for participation in recognised international com-

petitions are reimbursed up to ₹2 lakh per athlete. Under Achievement Recognition, athletes who perform exceptionally at state, national and international competitions receive cash incentives as prescribed under the scheme.

The Chief Minister said identifying and consistently developing talent from the grassroots level was essential for achieving excellence in sport, referencing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's repeated emphasis on building a strong, inclusive and future-ready sporting culture in the country.



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Wellington

New Zealand white-ball captain Mitchell Santner has turned down a Big Bash League contract to prioritise the Black Caps' Test assignments against India and Australia.

Santner was approached by Adelaide Strikers but decided against taking up the offer, with New Zealand's international commitments taking precedence.

“When you look ahead to the summer we've got, India here for white ball and Tests and Australia away - there's not many bigger than that - it's quite an exciting time. “I'd like to still be part of that,” Santner told the ‘New Zealand Herald’.

“The offer was good, I'm not going to lie. They knew it would have to be a good offer for me to entertain it with contracting and what would come up.

“I did entertain the thought of it, but coming back to what we've got coming up, even if I'm not going to play every game of Test cricket, I still feel like there's a role

for me,” he added. The Black Caps are scheduled to host India in a full series, including two Tests, from October 22 to December 1 before travelling across the Tasman for a four-Test series against Australia. The 34-year-old also remains keen to continue in leadership role and believes staying involved with national team is the better option at this stage of his career.